Sanatana Gosvami

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The Eldest of the Gosvamis

The six Gosvamis of Vrindavana established in the world the innermost desire of Sri Krishna Chaitanya, the avatara who purifies the Age of Kali, and the eldest of them was Sanatana. His contribution to the literary heritage of the Gaudiya sampradaya can be compared only with what Rupa and Raghunatha Dasa left behind.

Krishnadasa Kaviraja Gosvami says in a few words how each of three great associates served the Lord:

“Through Haridasa Thakura He revealed the glory of Krishna's holy names. And through Sanatana Gosvami He disclosed the essence of sacred devotion to God. Through Sri Rupa Gosvami He revealed the taste of transcendental loving relations with Krishna in Vrindavana.” (CC, Antya 5.86–87)

And of himself he says:

“By the mercy of Sanatana Gosvami I learned the truths of bhakti. And by the mercy of Sri Rupa Gosvami I tasted the nectar of loving relations with Sri Krishna.” (CC, Adi 5.203)

That is why Sanatana is called the bhakti-siddhantacharya — the teacher of the conclusions (siddhanta) of bhakti, that is, of sambandha-jnana: the knowledge of how God, the living being and the world are related to one another.

Through each of His close devotees Mahaprabhu gave the world one great teaching. The “Bhakti-ratnakara” says:

“Through Ramananda He revealed the crushing of Kandarpa's pride, through Damodara He revealed impartiality, through Haridasa He showed forbearance, through Sanatana and Rupa He revealed humility.” (“Bhakti-ratnakara,” 1.630–631)

Humility (dainya) became the mark of both brothers, and it will be spoken of more than once in this article.

In his song “Ke vaishnava?” (“Who Is a Vaishnava?”), which he gave to his disciples, Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati rebukes the crafty mind that makes a show of preaching “nirjana-bhajana,” solitary bhajana, like the feats of a yogi seeking mystic powers, and bids it reflect carefully on everything the Lord so painstakingly taught Sanatana. Srila Bhaktisiddhanta therefore teaches us to give special attention to the instructions Mahaprabhu gave the world through Sanatana: they are the remedy for a showy “solitary bhajana.”

Years of His Life

Unlike Rupa's dates, Sanatana's are the same in every known testimony. They are given by the note “Determining the Dates of the Six Gosvamis,” which Bhaktivinoda Thakura printed in the “Sajjana-toshani” (2nd year, 2nd issue); by the records collected by the late Vishvambharananda Deva Gosvami of the shripata of Gopivallabhapura; and by the information of Pandita Banamali Lala Gosvami of the Radha-ramana-ghera in Vrindavana. According to them, Sanatana appeared in 1410 of the Shaka era (1545 Samvat, 1488 AD).[1] He lived at home for twenty-seven years — until he met Mahaprabhu and left his family and his post as minister — spent forty-three years in Vraja, and remained on earth seventy years in all.

Sanatana departed in 1480 Shaka (1615 Samvat, 1558 AD), on the day of ashadha-purnima, displaying this pastime in the midst of preaching Gaurasundara's cherished desire. According to our Vaishnava calendar, the day of Srila Sanatana Gosvami's departure is the purnima of the month of Vamana: on that same day Guru- (Vyasa-) purnima is celebrated and chaturmasya begins.[2]

Lineage

Sanatana's genealogy over seven generations was preserved by his nephew Jiva Gosvami at the end of the “Laghu-vaishnava-toshani”; it is set out in detail in the article on Rupa Gosvami. The founder of the line was Sarvajna “Jagad-guru,” king of Karnata; after him came Aniruddha-deva and his son Rupeshvara, whose brother Harihara seized his kingdom, so that Rupeshvara went east with his wife to King Shikhareshvara. Rupeshvara's son Padmanabha settled on the Ganga at Navahatta (Naihati); his youngest son Mukunda-deva was Sanatana's grandfather, and Mukunda's son Kumara-deva was his father.[3] The pious Kumara-deva, because of strife in Naihati, moved to Bakla-Chandradvipa and, for his journeys, also made himself a residence at Fatehabad (then in the district of Jessore), between Naihati and Bakla.[4] Beyond this genealogy no reliable information about the family has been found; one can only hope that historians will find more.

The “Gaudiya-vaishnava-abhidhana” adds that Sanatana's grandfather Mukunda entered the court in the capital of Gauda as early as the reign of Barbak Shah (1460–1470). The times were troubled. Barbak Shah kept a great many Abyssinian slaves and eunuchs (“habshi”) at court and in the harem; after him reigned his son Yusuf, then Yusuf's son Fateh Shah. Under Fateh Shah the Abyssinians rose in revolt, killed him and ruled themselves for five or six years; Hussain Shah was vizier to the last of them and afterwards became ruler of Bengal himself.

Of Kumara-deva's sons three became famous: the eldest, Sanatana; the second, Rupa; and the youngest, Vallabha. There were other sons as well, but nothing is known of them.[5] Vallabha's only son was Jiva, the servant and nephew of Rupa and Sanatana — the very one who described the genealogy in the “Laghu-toshani.”

Youth and the “Bhagavatam”

After Kumara-deva passed away, the brothers lived and studied in the house of their maternal uncle, in a small village near the capital of Gauda.[6] The names “Rupa” and “Sanatana” were given to them later by Sri Chaitanya Himself; their former names are unknown, though some think that Sanatana was called Amara and Rupa Santosha.[7]

From childhood, one of the biographies relates, all three brothers lived in bhava-bhakti. Around their home in Ramakeli grew groves of tamala, keli-kadamba and tulasi; there were ponds there which the brothers named Radha-kunda and Shyama-kunda, and they served Sri Madana-mohana. Hearing of Gaurasundara's pastimes in Navadvipa, they longed to see Him, but an inner voice told them to wait. And when the news came that Sri Chaitanya had accepted sannyasa and gone to Puri, the brothers fainted, and they were consoled only by a voice from the sky: the merciful Gauranga would soon come to them. In this way the authors show that Sanatana and his brothers were not worldly men who came to faith in time, but eternal associates of the Lord.

Sanatana studied the shastras under Vidyavachaspati, the brother of Sarvabhauma Bhattacharya and the foremost scholar of the land. Narahari Chakravarti writes:

“Sri Sanatana's guru is Vidya-vachaspati; from time to time he stayed in the village of Ramakeli. Under him [Sanatana] studied all the shastras; what his devotion to his guru was cannot be told.” (“Bhakti-ratnakara,” 1.598–599)

Even before he outwardly displayed his coming to Mahaprabhu's feet, Sanatana was absorbed in the study of all the shastras, but he was especially devoted to the “Srimad Bhagavatam.”

This love, Jiva Gosvami tells at the end of the “Laghu-toshani,” was kindled in him by a wondrous dream. The young Sanatana dreamt of a brahmana who gave him the “Srimad Bhagavatam”; his hair stood on end, and the dream broke off. Waking and not finding the book, Sanatana was agitated. But the next morning, when he had bathed and sat down to worship, that very brahmana came with the “Bhagavata” and, according to one biography, said: “Take it and study it always, and all perfection will be yours.” Having given him the book, he went away, and Sanatana sank into an ocean of the nectar of love for Krishna. Narahari Chakravarti tells the same story in verse, following it with Jiva's own words:

“The life of Sri Sanatana is truly wondrous; he loves the Srimad Bhagavatam beyond measure. In his early youth, in a dream, a venerable brahmana with joy in his heart gives him the Srimad Bhagavatam. On waking, Sanatana was agitated — [and in waking life] that same brahmana lovingly handed him the Srimad Bhagavatam. Having received the Sri Bhagavata, with great joy at heart my master sank into the ocean of the nectar of prema. How he relished the meaning of the Srimad Bhagavatam he revealed in the Sri Vaishnava-toshani.” (“Bhakti-ratnakara,” 1.531–535)

“Those who in early youth received the Sri Bhagavata in a dream, and in the morning, awake, from the very brahmana they had seen in the dream, and sank into the great ocean of the nectar of prema for Bhagavan — this writing is truly theirs, of those called Sri Sanatana.” (“Laghu-toshani,” conclusion; “Bhakti-ratnakara,” 1.537–538)

From that day on, one biography says, Sanatana set other books aside and studied only the “Bhagavata,” as the essence of all scripture.[8]

Sanatana honoured his teachers at the beginning of the “Vaishnava-toshani,” his commentary on the Tenth Canto:

“I bow to my gurus — Bhattacharya Sarvabhauma and Vidya-vachaspati — and to Vidya-bhushana, the ornament of the land of Gauda. I bow to Sri Paramananda Bhattacharya, the lover of rasa, and also to Ramabhadra and Vani-vilasa, my instructors.” (“Vaishnava-toshani,” opening verses; “Bhakti-ratnakara,” 1.601–602)[9]

And in the “Krishna-lila-stava” he addresses the “Bhagavata” itself:

“You are my only friend, my companion, my guru, my great treasure, my deliverer, my good fortune, my bliss: obeisance to you!” (“Krishna-lila-stava”)

In the Service of Hussain Shah

The brothers' learning, intelligence, knowledge and noble character drew the attention of the ruler of Gauda, Hussain Shah. Sanatana, “a Brihaspati in intellect,” and Rupa, peerless in appearance and virtues, occupied the two highest posts at his court and received the titles Sakara Mallik and Dabir Khas; they became the Shah's “two hands” in the business of government. Sanatana was prime minister.[10] Rupa held another ministerial post — perhaps that of minister of finance, collector of revenue and treasurer — while Vallabha was chief superintendent of the mint; the Shah rewarded the brothers generously. Hindus at that time often had to serve a Muslim sovereign, and among such officials there were many devotees: Keshava Vasu Khan, Gopinatha Vasu, Purandara Khan, the physician Mukunda Kaviraja, Keshava Chhatri.

The “Gaudiya-vaishnava-abhidhana” tells of Sanatana's rise differently: Mukunda died under Fateh Shah, and his grandson was taken into the court in his place; Sanatana survived the years of the Abyssinians, and under Hussain Shah rose ever higher by his talents and at last became prime minister.

Sanatana himself did not want this post. Hussain Shah heard of the brothers' virtues from pious people and wished to give them office, and out of fear of the yavana king they could not refuse. Narahari Chakravarti writes:

“Sanatana and Rupa were great ministers in every respect: the king heard of them from the lips of respectable people. The king of Gauda, a yavana ruling many lands, summoned Sanatana and Rupa and gave them the burden of government. For fear of the mlechchhas they accepted the post, and through their efforts his kingdom grew.” (“Bhakti-ratnakara,” 1.581–583)

Sanatana was born into a high brahmana family, yet because he served a Muslim government he considered himself fallen and always behaved with the utmost humility. In the “Bhakti-ratnakara” the brothers say of themselves:

“‘Our father, on seeing a yavana, performed atonement, and we are in constant association with yavanas. Fawning, we go to the houses of yavanas’ — and therefore they consider themselves equal to mlechchhas. Their inner disposition is not at all like that, but in this they consider themselves the lowest of the low. When they sink into the ocean of humility, they consider themselves lower than mlechchhas and the rest. With the low-born there is always low dealing: that is why they speak of themselves as low-born. Though kings among brahmanas, with great grief in their hearts they never think of themselves as brahmanas.” (“Bhakti-ratnakara,” 1.609–614)[11]

This humility is not an admission of any real fall but an expression of great Vaishnava humility; for it Sanatana is glorified in the “Chaitanya-charitamrita” and was praised by Mahaprabhu Himself. By “lowness” he meant aversion to Krishna, and scripture confirms that a twice-born man devoid of devotion to Hari is lower than a dog-eater. It is the nature of devotees to hide themselves behind humility and so mislead those who have turned away from God, that they may serve Him unhindered: thus Mahaprabhu Himself called Himself “a Mayavadi sannyasi without prema-bhakti,” and Narottama Thakura called himself “a chandala.” Sanatana is an eternal associate of the Lord and cannot be fallen. His humility is beyond description, and one can only pray for shelter at his feet.

Even in service Sanatana went on studying the “Bhagavatam” and other books and longed constantly for shelter at the feet of Sri Krishna Chaitanya. From time to time he wrote humble letters to Mahaprabhu, and once the Lord answered him with a verse:

“A married woman attracted to another man only appears to be diligent in her household duties, while in her heart she anticipates the sweetness of a new meeting with her beloved.” (CC, Madhya 1.211)

The meaning of the verse, one biography explains, is this: just as such a woman, however busy with household work, always tastes in her heart the joy of meeting as she remembers her beloved, so a devotee on the path of raga, while outwardly carrying on worldly affairs as if absorbed in them, is inwardly united without cease with the remembrance of Krishna, whom he worships.

Ramakeli

The brothers' seat was Ramakeli, a shripata on the Ganga, right by the border, in the district of Maldah: some eight miles south of English Bazar and five or six miles from Maldah station. According to one biography, Sultan Barbak made Ramakeli the capital of Bengal in 1486; under the British it was a district headquarters; and many devotees lived there, among them Sri Nrisimha, the son of Advaita Acharya. The place is also called Gupta-Vrindavana, the “hidden Vrindavana.”

The brothers lived mostly in Ramakeli: there they studied all the shastras and duly honoured the brahmana Vaishnavas. Narahari Chakravarti describes their life thus:

“They settled in Gauda, in the village of Ramakeli; the very limit of wealth, a truly wondrous splendour! To the assembly of Sanatana and Rupa, who were like Indra, knowers of the shastras come from various lands. Singers, musicians, dancers and poets from every country are constantly in their service. They spend a great deal of money without cease, and no one is ever left without honour. Both always occupy themselves with all the shastras and refute and establish [doctrines] without effort. An interpretation of the nyaya-sutras that anyone made of his own is established only when Sanatana and Rupa have heard it. <…> The fame of their virtues spread everywhere; brahmanas came from Karnata and other lands. To the brahmanas from their native country Sanatana and Rupa gave all of them places to live near the Ganga. The village where the community of Bhattas lives is called Bhattavati; all there are knowers of the shastras, incomparable in all doctrines. With those brahmanas in the village of Ramakeli they joyfully carry out all their worldly affairs. How Rupa and Sanatana honour the communities of Vaishnavas cannot be described. How many brahmanas come from Navadvipa, and how they honour them all, I cannot tell.” (“Bhakti-ratnakara,” 1.585–597)[12]

The brothers' memorial places in Ramakeli are the tamala and kadamba under which they met the Lord, with an altar of His footprints; the temple of Madana-mohana, where Nitai-Gauranga and Advaita are also worshipped; the ponds Radha-, Shyama-, Surabhi-, Lalita- and Vishakha-kunda; Rupa-sagara and Sanatana-sagara; and the brothers' large houses in Ramakeli and in Fatehabad. The Madana-mohana of Ramakeli is still there; He is known as the Deity installed before Sanatana left home, and Sanatana himself served Him. The memorial places of Ramakeli are described more fully in the article on Rupa Gosvami. In June 1868 Bhaktivinoda Thakura visited the house of Rupa and Sanatana in Ramakeli.

Meeting the Lord

To draw “His servants” Sanatana and Rupa to His feet, Mahaprabhu chose a special way: on the pretext of a journey to Vrindavana He set out from Nilachala for Gauda and came to Ramakeli. Thus He met Rupa and Sanatana for the first time, and with them their younger brother Anupama — in 1513, according to one biography; by His will renunciation awoke in the brothers.[13] Hearing of the Lord's wondrous prema and seeing its power, even the badshah recognised Him as Ishvara and ordered that no one disturb the “Hindu prophet.” Keshava Chhatri played down the Lord's importance before the king and secretly advised the Lord to leave, while Rupa, the Dabir Khas, glorified the Lord to the sultan in private. All this is told in detail in the article on Rupa Gosvami.

Learning that Mahaprabhu was in Ramakeli, the brothers exchanged the robes of royal officials for inconspicuous clothes and came to Him secretly — first to Nityananda and Haridasa Thakura, “the crown jewels of the saviours of the fallen,” who informed the Lord.[14] With bunches of grass between their teeth, cloth around their necks and joined palms, sobbing with humility, the brothers fell prostrate at His feet. The Lord told them to rise, and with folded hands they offered the prayer recorded by Krishnadasa Kaviraja (CC, Madhya 1.188–206): we are lower than Jagai and Madhai, we are servants of meat-eaters, and no one but You can save us.

The Lord answered them (CC, Madhya 1.207–215):

“‘Listen, Dabir Khas. You and your brother are both My servants from long ago. From now on your names are Rupa and Sanatana. Give up your humility now, for it breaks My heart. <…> You are both My servants birth after birth. Very soon Sri Krishna will certainly set you free.’” (CC, Madhya 1.207–208, 215)

From their letters He knew their hearts and had more than once sent them, for their instruction, the verse about the woman drawn to her beloved; He had no business in Gauda — He had come to see the two of them, though no one knows why He came to Ramakeli. Placing His hands on their heads, the Lord sent

them home without fear. Thus Gaurasundara took from His eternal associates the names Dabir Khas and Sakara Mallik given by the badshah and named them Sri Rupa and Sri Sanatana. Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati explains ("Anubhashya" on CC, Madhya 1.208): by giving the brothers spiritual names the Lord showed them mercy; name-giving is a samskara of the lowest step, yet whoever neglects it remains in worldly pride, and the prakrita-sahajiyas, who wear neither the marks of a Vaishnava nor a name received from a guru, are not Gaudiya Vaishnavas.

Present at the meeting were Nityananda, Haridasa, Shrivasa, Gadadhara Pandita, Mukunda Datta, Jagadananda, Murari Gupta, Vakreshvara and many others; at the Lord's bidding the brothers touched their feet, and He told everyone to bless them. At that same time Vallabha, who became Anupama, also received mercy.

Vrindavana Dasa Thakura in the "Chaitanya-bhagavata" tells of the giving of the name differently — as an event in Nilachala, where the brothers came later: the Lord told them to beg for prema-bhakti at Advaita's feet and then to go to Mathura to preach bhakti. Vrindavana Dasa also names the brothers' former names — Sakara Mallik and Dabir Khas: at the very beginning of his poem he says that in the Antya-khanda Gaurasundara will reveal Himself to Dabir Khas, and that the two brothers, recognising the Lord, will attain liberation and receive new names — Rupa and Sanatana (CB, Adi 1.171–172); and in the account itself, that the Lord cast His merciful glance on the two brothers, "Sakara Mallik and Rupa" (CB, Antya 9.239). Sanatana he calls "Sanatana-avadhuta":

"sakara-mallika nama ghuchaiya tana / sanatana avadhuta thuilena nama" — "taking from him the name Sakara Mallik, [the Lord] named him Sanatana-avadhuta." (CB, Antya 9.273)

The note on this passage calls such a giving of a name the "third samskara."[15]

Seeing the huge crowds around the Lord, Sanatana, wise in worldly affairs, lovingly dissuaded Him from going to Vrindavana in this way. The Shah trusts You, he said, but he is a Muslim and cannot be relied upon; Your work here is done, and one does not go to Vrindavana as a pilgrim leading hundreds of thousands of people (CC, Madhya 1.222–224). Mahaprabhu acknowledged the advice as sound. Later He Himself recalled it:

"But as he was leaving, Sanatana said one mysterious phrase to Me: 'One who is setting out for Vrindavana should not lead a crowd of many thousands behind him.' At first I paid no attention to these words, and in the morning I set out for Kanai-natashala. But late at night I pondered Sanatana's words, which he had cast in the form of a profound aphorism. He spoke rightly: when countless people follow Me, ordinary people may easily take Me for an impostor." (CC, Madhya 16.265–269)[16]

Murari Gupta in his "Karcha" tells of the meeting at Ramakeli in his own way:

"Then Krishna, surrounded by His devotees, came to Ramakeli. Hearing of this, Sanatana came there to see the Lord's feet. Seeing the Lord, he rejoiced at heart; together with his younger brother he fell to the ground and, holding a straw between his teeth, said to Keshava: 'There is no sinner like me, no such offender anywhere. I am ashamed even to excuse myself — what can I say, O Purushottama?' Janardana placed His foot on his head and said, 'You are a dweller of Vrindavana — truly, truly, there is no doubt. I wish to go at leisure to Mathura together with you. But to reveal the lost holy places, and Vrindavana as well — that is your task: all of it will come about by My mercy — for My mercy is devotion itself embodied, and it bestows loving devotion.' Hearing this, the most wise Sri Sanatana, with his younger brother, said, 'Vrindavana is the pleasure-garden of Krishnachandra, lovely and auspicious: there Krishna plays for ever with Sri Radha <…>. With the sword of Your mercy You have cut my strong chain — my royal ministership and the rest — and brought me into Your presence. So now infuse Your power into me, O Krishna, and do as You please.'" (Murari Gupta's "Karcha," 3.18.1–10)

Having bestowed His mercy on the brothers, Mahaprabhu went as far as Kanai-natashala, where He saw pictures of Krishna's pastimes, and, pondering Sanatana's word, gave up the intention of going to Vrindavana with a crowd: He decided to go there alone or with one companion, and now turned back — through Shantipura to Puri.[17]

The Prisoner of Hussain Shah

What followed one of the biographies calls “a pastime of renunciation for the instruction of the people”: Sanatana's giving up his post and his journey in rags are shown as an example, not as a need of the Lord's eternal associate. From the time the brothers saw Mahaprabhu in Ramakeli, they sought a way to leave worldly life. Generously rewarding some brahmanas, they commissioned them to perform two purashcharanas of the Krishna mantra, so as to attain shelter at Sri Chaitanya's feet. Rupa and Sanatana are Krishna's eternal associates in Vrindavana, but in Gauranga's pastimes they appeared in the role of sadhakas.

Rupa brought a great deal of wealth by boat to his house in Fatehabad and divided it: half he gave to brahmanas and Vaishnavas, a quarter to his relatives, and a quarter he left with trustworthy brahmanas against misfortune; for Sanatana he left ten thousand coins in Gauda, and Sanatana deposited them with a merchant-banker (mahajana) and drew on them as needed.[18] Hearing that the Lord had returned from Ramakeli to Puri and would go from there to Vrindavana by the forest road, Rupa sent two messengers to Nilachala to learn the exact day of His departure.

Sanatana stayed in Ramakeli, looking for an opportunity to leave the royal service for ever. He reasoned: the king's love for me is my fetter, as is the love of any worldly man; only by incurring his displeasure shall I get the king to let me go. Hussain Shah did indeed love him and treated him like a younger brother. So Sanatana declared himself ill, gave up his duties and stopped appearing at court. Seeing his detachment, several kayastha officials under him began to show great zeal in the hope of getting his place; according to tradition, Sanatana's place was in fact taken by his subordinate, the well-known Purandara Khan.

Sanatana himself gathered twenty or thirty pandita-bhattacharyas at home and discussed the shastras and the “Bhagavatam” in their assembly. One day the badshah came to him unexpectedly with a single companion and found him in good health among the scholars; everyone rose, greeted him respectfully and seated him.[19]

“I sent a physician to you,” said the badshah, “and he reported that you are well. All my affairs depend on you, yet you sit at home, and everything is in disorder. Tell me plainly what is on your mind.” “I can no longer serve you,” Sanatana answered. “Let someone else manage the business.” The angry badshah exclaimed: “I am your elder brother! I do not govern the kingdom: I make war with my army and vassals, march through foreign lands, hunt in the district of Gauda and kill many animals, and you are my whole support. If I, the elder, am occupied only with plunder and violence to living beings, and you, the younger, have abandoned your duties — how is the kingdom to stand?” Sanatana replied with a hidden meaning: “You are the ruler of Gauda, independent and empowered to punish and reward: give each his due according to his fault.” In other words, the king, who himself behaved like a robber, would reap the fruit of it, and let him dismiss Sanatana, his negligent servant.

The badshah went back to his palace and, so that Sanatana would not escape, had him put under guard. When setting out on a campaign against Orissa, he called on Sanatana to go with him, but Sanatana answered: “You are making war on Vishnu, and I cannot assist you in that.” And the badshah went off to Orissa, leaving him in chains.[20]

When Mahaprabhu set out from Nilachala for Vrindavana, Rupa's messengers returned with the news, and Rupa, leaving at once for Vraja with Anupama, wrote to Sanatana: “Anupama and I are going to Vrindavana to Mahaprabhu's feet; break out of prison by any means and come to Vrindavana; free yourself quickly with the ten thousand coins kept with the mahajana in Ramakeli.” Bhaktivinoda Thakura (“Amrita-pravaha-bhashya,” 2.20.3) reports that the letter was a Sanskrit verse: “Where is Mathura, the city of the lord of the Yadavas? Where is Koshala of the lord of the Raghus? Remembering this, make your mind steady: this world is not eternal.” Sanatana understood its hidden meaning — the Lord had gone to Mathura — and, rejoicing, began to think of escape.[21] And in Prayaga the Lord, hearing from Rupa that Sanatana was in prison, foretold that he would soon be freed and come to Him.

Having received the letter, Sanatana began to win over with kind words the jailer, whom he himself had once appointed to that post: “You are a living pir, fortunate and well versed in the Koran; if you free me, an innocent prisoner, Khoda will free you from the world. I once helped you a great deal — repay me; I will give you five thousand coins — you will have both dharma and wealth.” The jailer wavered: “I am not unwilling to release you, but I fear the badshah.” “Do not be afraid,” said Sanatana. “The badshah has gone on campaign to the south. When he returns, tell him: Sakara Mallik went to the Ganga to relieve himself, saw the water close by and threw himself into it; I searched for a long time, but in his leg-irons he went under and was carried away — I found no trace. As for me, I shall not stay in this country: I shall become a dervish and go to Mecca.”[22]

Krishnadasa Kaviraja gives these words thus:

“You need not be afraid, for I will not remain here. I will become a dervish, an ascetic, and go to Mecca.” (CC, Madhya 20.13)

For Sanatana the dervish's guise and the words about Mecca were only a means of concealing himself and getting out of captivity, not a teaching; therefore the traditions relied on by people with ulterior desires (the name “Amara,” an initiation he supposedly gave to the Oriya poet Achyuta Dasa, the appeal of various sects and of the aulas and bauls to his dervish dress) should be accepted with great caution.

Seeing that the jailer still hesitated, Sanatana laid before him a heap of seven thousand coins from the money Rupa had left. The man could not resist: he cut the fetters and at night ferried him across the Ganga.[23]

Flattery, a reminder of past favours, temptation, advice to lie, a bribe — the means Sanatana resorted to are usually considered unworthy. But he used them in the service of the Lord, and the purity of the means is determined by the purity of the goal. Hanuman burned Lanka for Rama's sake, and everyone received good from it; a soldier who kills enemies for his country is rewarded, not executed; all the more justified is an act done for the Lord of countless universes. The “Padma Purana” says this too: “A sin committed for My sake becomes dharma; and dharma without regard for Me becomes sin — such is My power.” And Krishna says in the “Gita” (18.17): one who is free from false ego and whose intelligence is unstained, even if he kills, does not kill and is not bound. On the other hand, outward piety for the sake of harming others is tamas, and chanting the Name for worldly ends is a sin.

Across the Patra Hills

With his servant Ishana, long his personal attendant, Sanatana walked day and night without rest — not by the high road but across fields and through villages: the former prime minister fled almost penniless. So he came to the Patra hills, which are considered part of the Rajmahal hills in the region of Chota Nagpur, now in the state of Bihar.[24]

There he met a landholder, a bhuinya, who was a chief of robbers, and asked him to take him across the hills. The bhuinya had an astrologer who could tell by calculation how much money and goods a

traveller was carrying, and the bhuinya himself would kill travellers and take their possessions. The astrologer said that Sanatana had eight gold mohurs, and the chief received him with special honour: he promised to take him across the hills that night with his men and gave him rice and everything needed for cooking.[25] Sanatana bathed in the river and, after fasting for two days, cooked a meal and ate.

But the wise minister suspected something was wrong: why such honour, when he had nothing with him? He asked Ishana, and Ishana admitted that he was carrying seven mohurs. “Why did you bring this death along with you?” Sanatana gently reproached him. He himself took the seven mohurs to the bhuinya: “Take them and get me across the hills. I am a royal prisoner; if you help me across, you will earn merit.” The bhuinya laughed: “I already knew there were eight mohurs in your servant's bundle. It is well that I have been spared a sin — otherwise tonight I would have killed you both and taken them. I am pleased with your honesty: I will not take the mohurs and will take you across for the sake of piety.” “If you do not take them,” Sanatana answered, “someone else will kill me and take them. Take them and save my life.” He remembered the sayings: “Even the favour of a man of unsteady mind is dangerous,” and “How can one trust a rogue's words? Now truth, now falsehood — like the clouds of the month of shravana: now sunshine, now a downpour.” The bhuinya gave him four guards (paiks), and that same night they took him across the hills by a forest path.

Beyond the hills Sanatana told Ishana that he knew he still had money left. Ishana, who had kept back the eighth coin, produced it. Sanatana told him to take that mohur for the road and go home, and he himself went on alone, with a karanga, a water-pot, in his hand and wearing a torn kantha.[26] When causeless devotion appears in the heart, a person ceases to care for worldly happiness: renunciation is only a by-product of selfless devotion. And by sending away Ishana, who was attached to a gold coin, Sanatana showed that when the unready take up renunciation, the very order of renunciation is defiled.

Walking on fearlessly, he came to Hajipur, on the northern bank of the Ganga opposite Patna, where the Ganga meets the Gandaki. There his sister's husband Shrikanta was buying horses for Hussain Shah. Seeing Sanatana from a high place, he came to him at night, heard his story and urged him to stay with him for a day or two, take off his dirty clothes, shave and dress decently.[27] “I will not stay here for a moment,” Sanatana answered. “Take me across the Ganga quickly: I am leaving at once.” With difficulty Shrikanta persuaded him to accept a bhota-kambala, a costly Tibetan woollen blanket, and took him across the Ganga.[28]

In Kashi at Gaura's Feet

A few days later Sanatana reached Varanasi and heard with great joy that Mahaprabhu was there. In Kashi the Lord was staying in the house of Chandrashekhara, a copyist of manuscripts, a vaidya by caste.[29] Sanatana sat down by the door without entering the house. The omniscient Lord said to Chandrashekhara: “There is a Vaishnava at the door — call him in.” Sanatana had neither proper clothes nor the marks of a Vaishnava, and Chandrashekhara replied: “There is no Vaishnava there, only some dervish sitting.” But at the Lord's bidding he called in the “dervish” too.

Seeing Sanatana in the courtyard, Mahaprabhu rushed to him, embraced him and was overwhelmed with prema. Sanatana, stammering with emotion, kept saying in his humility: “Do not touch me, Lord, I am very low.” Chandrashekhara watched in amazement as both wept with love. The Lord lovingly seated Sanatana beside Him and with His own hands began to wipe the dust of the road from him, and to his humble words He replied:

“‘Touching you purifies Me Myself, for by the power of your bhakti you can purify the whole universe. <…> One who sees you, touches you and glorifies you uses his senses for their true purpose. Such is the verdict of the scriptures. <…> Sri Krishna is inexpressibly merciful. He is the Saviour of all fallen souls.

He has rescued you from the pit of worldly life, which is like the hellish worlds. He is an ocean of compassion, and His deeds are deep, inconceivable and boundless.'" (CC, Madhya 20.56, 60, 62–63)[30]

Sanatana is an eternal associate of the Lord, and the words about rescue from hell are addressed to the world: worldly honour, measured by wealth and sense objects, is in truth a misfortune and leads to hell; rare is the householder who knows that the true enjoyer is Krishna and gives everything to Him. "I do not know Krishna," said Sanatana. "I have been saved only by Your mercy." At the Lord's request he told the whole story of his escape, and the Lord told him that He had met his brothers Rupa and Anupama in Prayaga and that both had gone to Vrindavana. At His word Sanatana made the acquaintance of Tapana Mishra and Chandrashekhara; Tapana Mishra invited him to a meal at his house. The Lord stayed with Chandrashekhara but took His meals with Tapana Mishra, and Sanatana received His remnants.

During the days of prison and travel Sanatana's hair and beard had grown long. The Lord told Chandrashekhara to take the dervish's clothes off him and have him shaved; Chandrashekhara had him shaved, bathed him in the Ganga and brought new clothes. Sanatana would not take them: "If you wish to give me clothing, give me your old cloth." So Mishra gave him his worn cloth, and Sanatana divided it into two outer cloths (bahirvasa) and a proper belt and kaupina. The Lord was very pleased.[31] Vaishnavas usually shave clean, except during chaturmasya, when they neither shave nor cut their nails, while Vaishnava sannyasis shave once a month, at the full moon: frequent shaving would be excessive care for the body.

The Lord rejoiced in Sanatana's renunciation, for, as Krishnadasa Kaviraja says,

"Mahaprabhu's devotees have many different virtues. But the chief quality that so greatly pleases Sri Chaitanya is their detachment from everything worldly." (CC, Antya 6.220)[32]

When the desire to serve the Lord is genuine, a person is indifferent to fine clothes and food; the exception is the gifts of Vaishnavas and their remnants, which hold no poison of sense objects. Every act of Sanatana's here is a lesson to the sadhaka.

The Lord introduced Sanatana to a brahmana from Maharashtra, who asked him always to eat at his house while he was in Kashi. But Sanatana declined such abundant alms: he wished to gather madhukari from different houses. The Lord was boundlessly pleased with his yukta-vairagya: a pure devotee does not seek bodily comfort.

The Lord, however, kept glancing at the bhota-kambala. Understanding that it displeased Him, Sanatana resolved to give the blanket away. At midday by the Ganga a man from Gauda was drying his washed kantha, and Sanatana asked him to make an exchange. "You are a sensible man — why exchange a costly blanket for my torn kantha?" the man wondered. "I am telling the truth, I am not joking," Sanatana replied, made the exchange and came to the Lord in the kantha, and when asked where the blanket was, told the whole story.[33] The Lord said:

"'I have been thinking about this. Lord Sri Krishna is boundlessly merciful, and therefore He has destroyed all your worldly attachments. Why then would He leave in you anything worldly to which you might be even slightly attached? Having cured a patient, a good physician will not allow even the slightest trace of the disease to remain in his body. This blanket, worth three gold coins, is not compatible with the life of an ascetic living on alms. For an ascetic to wear it violates the laws of dharma and gives occasion for ridicule.'" (CC, Madhya 20.90–92)[34]

If conduct and preaching do not agree, one's own dharma perishes and one becomes a laughing-stock; whomever Krishna favours without guile, He frees from the disease of worldliness completely, to the last trace. The Lord, though Bhagavan Himself, played the role of the supreme teacher and required of

His associates what He taught and Himself practised: “Whatever the best do, others follow” (“Bhagavad-gita,” 3.21; cf. CC, Adi 3.20–21). And Sanatana replied: “By the will and mercy of Him who put an end to my wicked enjoyments, the last disease of worldliness too has gone.”

It is said that at Etawah on the Yamuna, on the way from Prayaga to Mathura, a blanket is worshipped in a certain temple, and the local pujaris say that Sri Chaitanya gave it to a poor man. Some guess that this is the very blanket Sanatana gave away in Kashi: that man from Gauda, later learning the greatness of Chaitanya and Sanatana, worshipped it with love, while the uninformed, taking Sanatana for Chaitanya Himself, regarded the blanket as the Lord's gift. However, there is no such tradition in Bhaktivinoda Thakura's article “Etawah on the Bank of the Yamuna” (“Sajjana-toshani,” 4th year).

Two Months in Kashi

Pleased with Sanatana, the Lord showered His mercy on him and, investing him with power, moved him to ask questions for the good of all living beings. As formerly the Lord Himself had questioned Ramananda Raya and Ramananda had answered by His power, so now Sanatana asked by the Lord's power, and the Lord Himself answered. Without the Lord's mercy genuine questions about spiritual life do not arise: questions asked for the sake of argument are fruitless, while “pariprashna,” the humble inquiry the “Gita” speaks of (4.34), leads to surrender. An eternally liberated associate of the Lord, Sanatana showed what a sadhaka should ask his guru on the day he meets him. Krishnadasa Kaviraja set out these conversations in detail in the “Chaitanya-charitamrita” (Madhya 20–24); the biographies give them briefly, and here only their course and principal ideas will be named.

They embraced the whole edifice of Vaishnava philosophy: the eternal nature of the jiva as Krishna's servant and the Lord's three energies — svarupa-shakti, maya-shakti and tatastha-shakti; the parable of the omniscient astrologer, in which the paths of karma, knowledge and bhakti are compared; Krishna as the goal of all the shastras; His forms, expansions and avataras; Goloka and Vaikuntha, the Lord's majesty and sweetness; the means of attaining prema and the two classes of living beings; the fruitlessness of karma, knowledge and yoga without bhakti and the worthlessness of varnashrama without Krishna; the guru who initiates, the guru who instructs and the inner guru; the growth of faith, the three grades of devotees and the twenty-six qualities of a Vaishnava; sadhu-sanga; bhakti according to rules and raganuga-bhakti, the sixty-four angas and the five best of them; bhava and prema, Krishna's sixty-four qualities; true and false renunciation; the story of Narada and the hunter and the sixty-one explanations of the “atmarama” verse.

With grass between his teeth, clasping the Lord's feet, Sanatana asked:

“‘I am of low birth, unworthy and fallen. Having fallen into the well of sinful materialistic enjoyments, all my life I have been surrounded only by base people. I do not understand at all what is good for me and what is not. Yet ordinary people consider me a pandita, a knower of the scriptures, and even I have come to think so of myself. Since You have saved me by Your causeless mercy, kindly explain to me what my duty is now. Who am I? Why am I subject to the threefold miseries? I cannot understand this. How am I to attain the good? I know nothing of the goal of life or the means of attaining it. Be merciful and explain all these truths to me.’” (CC, Madhya 20.99–103)

The Lord answered: Krishna's full mercy is in you, you know all the truths, and the threefold miseries no longer exist for you; but a saint, though knowing everything, asks again in order to become firm in knowledge, and you are worthy to spread bhakti. Inquiry into the truth is the jiva's first step towards the good: one whose desire to awaken sad-dharma, true dharma, is firm soon reaches the goal, and the question “Who am I?” makes the jiva fit for sambandha-jnana. A mistake in self-knowledge leads to a mistake in the goal, and then every effort is in vain: one who takes himself to be the gross body

measures duty and morality by the good of the body; one who takes himself to be the subtle body, by the development of the mind; while one who knows himself to be the soul seeks the good of the soul and uses both bodies in the way that is favourable to it.

“Who Am I?”

“Being a manifestation of Sri Krishna's marginal energy, the living being is simultaneously one with the Lord and different from Him. Therefore his purpose is eternal loving service to Sri Krishna. The eternal relationship of the soul and God can be understood by the example of a ray and the sun, or of a spark and a bright flame.” (CC, Madhya 20.108–109)

The “I” is neither the gross body nor the subtle body (mind, intelligence and false ego): the true “I” is the eternal servant of Krishna, His tatastha-shakti. It stands on the border between the spiritual world and the world of maya and is therefore connected with both. As a shore lies between water and land and partakes of both, so this shakti bears in itself the properties of both sides: by nature the jiva is consciousness, but by its constitution it can fall under the sway of matter. The jiva and Krishna are simultaneously different and non-different. By spiritual nature the jiva, a separated particle of Krishna, is also full of being, consciousness and bliss; but it is atomic, its consciousness is small, while Krishna is all-pervading consciousness, and so the jiva is not complete as He is. The shruti says so too: “As tiny sparks fly out from a fire…” (“Brihad-aranyaka Upanishad,” 2.1.20): living beings issue from the Supreme like rays from the sun of Krishna or sparks from a blazing fire, yet keep their separate existence.

Losing the awareness “I am Krishna's eternal servant,” the jiva falls into the bonds of maya: standing on the border, it desired to enjoy maya and entered it. The reckoning of material time begins with that entry, while aversion to Krishna arose before that reckoning — and that is why it is called “beginningless.” Such a jiva now suffers, now enjoys, now in heaven, now in hell, but both conditions are captivity: having turned away from Krishna, it sinks into maya, and fear and distorted memory are born in it. Seeing this, boundlessly merciful Krishna revealed the Vedas, the Puranas and other shastras, and Himself — in the form of the shastras, of gurus and sadhus who disclose their meaning, and as the Paramatma within — gives the jiva knowledge of its true nature.

“The Vedic scriptures speak of three truths: sambandha, abhidheya (the path) and prayojana (the highest goal). Sambandha means the eternal relationship of the soul and Krishna. The path to the highest goal is known as bhakti, loving service to God. Therefore bhakti and abhidheya are in essence one and the same. And the highest goal is prema (love of God), which is the supreme good and wealth of every soul.” (CC, Madhya 20.124–125)

The shrutis speak both of the oneness and of the difference of the jiva and God, and acharyas have explained this in different ways — as advaita-, dvaita-, vishishta-advaita-, shuddha-advaita-, dvaita-advaita-vada and so on. But in accepting scripture one must accept it whole and reconcile its apparent contradictions. The Lord's resolution is the teaching of achintya-bheda-abheda, inconceivable oneness and difference; accepting the whole of scripture and reconciling its apparent contradictions, it brought about a revolution in theistic thought.

Then the Lord gave an example. An omniscient astrologer revealed to a poor brahmana that his father's treasure lay buried under his courtyard: “Do not dig from the south — wasps will sting you; from the north — a black python will swallow you; from the west a yaksha, the guardian of the treasure, will hinder you; dig a little from the east, and you will find it.” The south is the path of karma: those who seek fruits are stung by the wasps of desire for enjoyment. The north is the path of knowledge, merging into Brahman, which like a python swallows the soul. The west is the path of yoga: the yaksha of desire for siddhis lures with powers and wealth and likewise ruins the soul. The east is the path of bhakti: there

the sun of prema rises. Release from poverty, that is, from the hardships of samsara, is not the fruit of prema: just as thieves and robbers flee already at dawn, before the sun has risen, so at the mere glimmer of prema all worldly hardships vanish easily and without remainder. Freedom from suffering is a by-product, not the goal. The three great treasures are Krishna, krishna-bhakti and prema.

Krishna and His Forms

Directly and indirectly all the Vedas speak only of Krishna. Infinite Krishna has infinite energies, and His natural threefold shakti is chit-shakti, maya-shakti and jiva-shakti: from chit-shakti comes the spiritual world, from unconscious maya the material world. Krishna is the non-dual truth, all-embracing being, consciousness and bliss, the source of all avataras and the origin of all, the crown of youths with a body of consciousness and bliss, the son of the king of Vraja, Bhagavan Himself, eternally dwelling in Goloka. He is realised by three paths and in three aspects: by knowledge without distinctions, as the impersonal Brahman, the effulgence of His body; by eightfold yoga, as the Paramatma, the majesty of His portion; by pure bhakti, as the complete Bhagavan.

The Lord divided Krishna's forms into three kinds. The first is the svayam-rupa: Krishna Himself in Vraja, the son of the king of Vraja, in the dress and self-awareness of a cowherd boy, the Lila-purushottama; together with His svayam-prakashas — prabhava (one body in many, as in the rasa-lila and at the weddings with the queens) and vaibhava (Baladeva, and the two-armed and four-armed Devakinandana). The second is the tad-ekatma-rupa. These are the vilasas: the first chatur-vyuha — Vasudeva, four-armed, in the dress and self-awareness of a kshatriya, eternally dwelling in the city, and Sankarshana, Pradyumna and Aniruddha; the second chatur-vyuha in Vaikuntha; three forms from each of its members — the twelve lords of the months and of the twelve tilakas; and the eight vilasas — Purushottama, Achyuta, Nrisimha, Janardana, Hari, Krishna, Adhokshaja, Upendra. They are also the svamshas, of six kinds: the three purusha-avataras, the three guna-avataras, the twenty-five lila-avataras (from Matsya to Kalki), the four yuga-avataras, the fourteen manvantara-avataras and the shaktyavesha-avataras. The third kind is avesha: bhagavad-avesha (Kapila, Rishabha) and shaktyavesha (Narada, Vyasa, Prithu, Brahma, Sanaka and others).

The svayam-rupa is Bhagavan Himself, and from His bhagavatta comes the bhagavatta of all others. The tad-ekatma is not different from the svayam-rupa but differs somewhat in form. Avesha is the entry of one of the shaktis, and only into the greatest jivas: of bhakti into Narada, of the power to sustain the world into Prithu, of knowledge into the Chatuhsana; those pervaded by Bhagavan Himself (Kapila, Rishabha) think, “I am Bhagavan,” while those pervaded by His shakti (Brahma, Narada, Vyasa) think, “I am Bhagavan's servant.”

“When the one Supreme Lord expands Himself into forms between which there is no difference at all, this is called ‘prakasha.’ So did Krishna in order to marry sixteen thousand princesses in Dvaraka, or when He enjoyed the rasa dance.” (CC, Adi 1.69–70)

“But the many forms of God between which there are some differences are known as ‘vilasa’ (sportive).” (CC, Adi 1.76)

A prakasha is equal to the original in every respect; a vilasa is equal in power but different in form, colour and name, like Balarama in Vraja and Narayana in Vaikuntha; a svamsha is of lesser power, like Matsya or Kurma. Prabhava means sovereignty, vaibhava all-embracing greatness. The prabhava-prakasha of the svayam-rupa is Krishna Himself; the vaibhava-prakasha is Balarama in Vraja, the original Sankarshana, from whom the first chatur-vyuha proceeds: in Dvaraka, in Mathura (two-armed forms) and in the spiritual sky — four-armed Narayana. Special forms for special purposes, like the four-armed or two-armed Devakinandana, are also prakashas of the svayam-rupa.

The purusha-avataras are these. Karanarnavashayi Maha-Vishnu is the inner controller of causal prakriti, the creator of the mahat-tattva, a portion of Maha-Sankarshana, the second of the vyuhas of Vasudeva, the Lord of the spiritual sky; Ananta, on whose couch He reclines, is the avatara Shesha, service to Krishna personified. Chit-shakti manifests Vaikuntha, Goloka and the other abodes, while maya-shakti creates Devi-dhama — the fourteen worlds. Garbhodakashayi is the inner controller of the subtle aggregate universe, the creator of Brahma, a portion of Pradyumna. Kshirodakashayi, the Paramatma, is the controller of the gross universe and of every jiva, a portion of Aniruddha. This successive manifestation shows the Lord's property of expanding ("charishnu-dharma"); therefore Ishvara is Vishnu alone, while the other two guna-avataras and all the devas are adhikarika-tattvas subordinate to Him. From Govinda, "the great lamp," through His vilasa-murti proceed the three purusha-avataras, and the svamsha-avataras, like Rama and Nrisimha, are like lamps lit from Him: equal to Him in qualities and in essence not different from Govinda, but different in pastimes.

Of the guna-avataras, Vishnu, Kshirodakashayi, maintains the world through sattva; He is of one nature with Govinda — pure sattva, equal qualities, beyond maya and the gunas, the Supreme, the master of maya. Brahma is born from the lotus of Garbhodakashayi's navel and creates through rajas; he is a separated particle, partly endowed with the power of a svamsha, agitated by rajas. In one kalpa the power of Bhagavan enters a worthy jiva, and Brahma is an avesha-avatara, but because of rajas he is not equal to Vishnu; in a kalpa where there is no such jiva, Vishnu Himself becomes Brahma. So it is too with Indra and the other appointed devas. Brahma is higher than ordinary jivas but is not Ishvara: he has the fifty qualities of a jiva in full and five more in part. The aggregate of the fourteen worlds from Patala to Satyaloka is his gross body, also called "Brahma"; the subtle jiva within it is Hiranyagarbha, and his inner controller is Garbhodakashayi.

Shiva (Shambhu) is likewise a separated particle, partly endowed with the power of a svamsha, agitated by the tamas of maya. He is not an Ishvara separate from Krishna — one who thinks so offends Bhagavan — and his lordship is subordinate to Govinda. He is simultaneously different and non-different from Vishnu: different because of the transformation caused by contact with maya, non-different because, as a Vaishnava-tattva taking shelter in the spiritual vilasa, he is free from transformation. So milk, by the action of a culture, becomes curd: born of milk, it is no longer milk; Vishnu Himself, like milk, never changes, and wherever a transformation under the influence of maya is seen in the divine, there another guna-avatara is at work — Brahma or Shiva. The tamas of maya, the smallness of the tatastha-shakti and the samvit of the chit-shakti with a slight admixture of hladini form a special transformation; with it combines a reflection of the svamsha — this is Ishvara Sadashiva in the form of the radiant shambhu-linga, and from him Rudra appears.

The shastras call Shambhu the best of Vaishnavas ("Bhagavatam," 12.13.16: "vaishnavanam yatha shambhuh"). By Govinda's will he unites by his power of time with Durga and, with the help of tamo-guna, carries out destruction. In the tantras and other shastras Shambhu gives instructions on dharma suited to different levels of jivas, as steps towards bhakti; by Govinda's will he also established mayavada and thereby guards the truth of pure bhakti. He has the fifty qualities of a jiva in full and five great ones, beyond the reach of a jiva, in part; therefore he cannot be called a jiva: he is a lord of jivas, though he belongs to the vibhinnamshas. In one kalpa a worthy jiva becomes Shiva the destroyer; in another, if there is no such jiva, Vishnu Himself assumes the form of Shiva; all these destroyers are guna-avataras. But Sadashiva, who dwells in Shivaloka within Vaikuntha, is not a guna-avatara: he is beyond the gunas and, like Narayana, is a vilasa of Krishna's svayam-rupa, the whole (amshi) of which the guna-avatara Shiva is a part; therefore he is higher than Brahma and not different from Vishnu. The Lord said:

“Brahma and Shiva are only executors of the Lord's will in the form of His devoted servants (bhaktas), while Vishnu Himself, as Krishna's personal manifestation, is the Maintainer of the whole creation.” (CC, Madhya 20.317)

The yuga-avataras come white in the Satya-yuga, red in the Treta, dark in the Dvapara, and in the Kali-yuga yellow, as the preacher of prema for the Name: in Kali Krishna Himself, the source of avataras, descends and spreads the dharma of this age — nama-kirtana. And here Sanatana — knower of the truth of Gaura-lila, expert in bhajana, “a Brihaspati in intellect” — wished to hear from the Lord's own lips about His own descent and boldly asked: “I am a low, insignificant jiva; how am I to know who the avatara in Kali is?” The Lord answered: the avatara in Kali, like all others, is recognised through the shastras; an avatara never says of himself, “I am an avatara,” and the wise identify him by the svarupa-lakshana, the marks of his nature, and the tatastha-lakshana, the marks of his deeds. Then Sanatana, wishing the Lord to acknowledge His own pastime, said: in Kali the svarupa-lakshana of the yuga-avatara is a yellow form, the tatastha — sankirtana in the bliss of prema; “so tell me who this Krishna-avatara in Kali is, and dispel my doubt.” The Lord, somewhat abashed, answered: “Sanatana, give up your cleverness; listen rather about the shaktyavesha-avataras.” Here, says one biography, the devotee won and Bhagavan was defeated: Sanatana forced the Lord into silence, and He, guarding His concealment, moved on to another subject.

Shaktyavesha-avataras are of two kinds: principal, when the shakti itself descends, and secondary, when only a reflection of the shakti is seen as a vibhuti. Before manifesting His pastimes, Krishna sends His servants into the world in the role of elders and teachers. In all the universes, uninterruptedly, like the flow of the Ganga, Krishna's manifold, ever-new pastimes on earth are revealed: in one universe they last one hundred and twenty-five years — from His birth to the mushala-lila — and are then withdrawn. When in one universe the first moment of the lila ends and the second begins, the pastimes of the first moment appear in another; thus in the endless universes the pastimes rise and set in order, without interruption, like the flow of the Ganga or the circle of fire made by a whirling torch. Krishna's birth, childhood, boyhood, youth and other pastimes take place eternally, and the simultaneous eternal manifestation of all the pastimes is the nitya-lila; in the world they are seen in sequence, and in a single universe their eternity is not visible, because the other pastimes are going on at that time in other universes. That is why the Vedas and Puranas speak of the eternal lila.

All the abodes of Vishnu are the spiritual opulence of Sankarshana, and each, by Krishna's will, descends into the world together with Hari. In Vraja Krishna displays all His majesty and sweetness — there He, the son of the king of Vraja, is “most complete” (purnatama); in Dvaraka and Mathura He is “more complete” (purnatara), and in Vaikuntha, in the spiritual sky, “complete” (purna). In the spiritual sky there eternally exist countless Vaikunthas of all the forms of Vishnu, and as the nature of each is eternal, so are His abode, associates and pastimes; the Lord's abode and form are of one shuddha-sattva, a spiritual nature inaccessible to the material senses, even to Brahma's. The spiritual world is like a lotus: in the middle, like the seed-pod, is Krishnaloka, and around it, like petals, are countless Vaikunthas. Krishna's three abodes are Gokula (Goloka), Mathura and Dvaraka, and He is the Lord of all three.

Krishna Himself is captivated by the sweetness of His human-like pastimes: of all pastimes the best is the spiritual nara-lila, of all forms the spiritual human-like body, the two-armed ever-youthful form with the flute. Krishna is the vishaya, the object of love, and the shaktis who depend on Him are the ashraya, its abode; the form of the vishaya captivates all: Narayana and Lakshmi are drawn by Krishna's form, and Krishna Himself longs to relish His own beauty. This sweetness is realised only by ardent bhakti following the ragatmika. Krishna is the shelter of all spiritual virtues, an ocean of the nectar of all rasas; in Vraja all the other aspects of Bhagavan proceed from the son of the king of Vraja Himself. The nectar

of His lotus face never cloys, as worldly things do, and the ocean of the gopis' bliss grows at every moment. The kama-gayatri is Krishna Himself: each of its syllables is one of the parts of His body.

Bhakti — the Path

Having set out sambandha, the Lord passed on to abhidheya, the means by which it is attained: the Shruti, Smriti, Puranas and Pancharatra name this means krishna-bhakti. Shakti and the possessor of shakti are non-different; the svarupa-shakti, engaged solely in Krishna's service, is distinct from maya-shakti and abides inseparably with Him; the svamshas and vilasas — the chatur-vyuha and the avataras — are Krishna Himself, shaktiman-tattva, while the jiva is a separated particle, shakti-tattva.

Jivas are of two kinds. The eternally liberated have never known maya; turned towards Krishna's feet in His abode, they are called His associates, and their only goal is the happiness of service. The eternally conditioned are turned away from Krishna and taste worldly joy and sorrow, heaven and hell. For this aversion maya, like a witch, binds them with gross and subtle coverings and punishes them with the three kinds of misery; in the power of the six enemies — lust, anger and the rest — they suffer from the disease of samsara, and the “swing” of karma carries them up and down. But if such a jiva receives the mercy of a sadhu, the skilled physician, maya flees from the mantra of his instruction, and the jiva attains krishna-bhakti and comes to Krishna's feet — to eternal service and lila.

In places the shastras call karma, yoga or knowledge the means, but everywhere they name bhakti as the chief and eternal means: it alone leads directly to prema, while the fruits of the other paths depend on it — karma and hatha-yoga give enjoyment, knowledge and raja-yoga give liberation and siddhis only under its cover. When bhakti turned towards Krishna dawns, mukti comes of itself, without the labour of knowledge: mukti is the maidservant of bhakti. The eternal good lies only on the path of bhakti, and dry knowledge is wasted toil. The only way out of the bondage born of forgetting one's eternal service to Krishna is ninefold bhakti (hearing, chanting and the rest) together with service at the feet of a guru who is close to Krishna and sent by Him. Even faultless varnashrama without bhakti does not save one from the hell Raurava; but whoever even once, with body, mind and speech, says “Krishna, I am Yours” and surrenders to Him, him Krishna certainly frees from the bonds of maya.

Bad company breeds desires for liberation, enjoyment and mystic powers; good company breeds renunciation of them and pure bhakti: one who began bhajana for some petty desire but in the company of sadhus took up pure bhajana loses that desire and attains krishna-rasa — so pure and powerful is the bhajana of Krishna. When the time of liberation comes, the jiva by good fortune meets a sadhu, and from that association rati for Krishna is born; and if at first such a pious person does not meet a great guru, Krishna Himself, as the inner guru, teaches him pure bhakti. Without bathing in the dust of the feet of the mahajanas, bhakti cannot be attained by austerity, Vedic worship, vows, household dharma, study of the Vedas or the worship of water, fire and sun; the good that comes from association with Bhagavan's associates cannot be compared with heaven or with liberation.

In the “Gita” Krishna gave the most confidential instruction: by the rule “the later injunction is stronger,” bhakti is higher than karma, knowledge and yoga, and He told us to abandon all dharmas and surrender to Him. Firm faith in this is the shraddha that gives the right to bhakti. Those who have it are of the highest, middle and beginning grades: the highest is versed in the shastras and in reasoning, and his faith is firm; the middle one does not know the firm arguments of the shastras but has faith; the beginner's faith is not yet firm, and knowledge and karma are mixed with it; when that admixture goes, the sadhaka becomes a middle devotee, and when his faith is strengthened by the arguments of the shastras, a highest one. By the degree of rati and prema one distinguishes the “bhakta,” the “bhaktatara” and the “bhaktatama”; a pure devotee is adorned with all Krishna's qualities.

A Vaishnava avoids the company of those attached to women and illicit connections and of Mayavadis hostile to Krishna, and associates with nishkinchana maha-bhagavatas; a nishkinchana gives up both kinds of bad company and even attachment to varnashrama and, possessing nothing, takes refuge in Krishna alone. The six signs of surrender (sharanagati) are these: to accept what is favourable to bhakti, to reject what is unfavourable, to believe that Krishna will protect, to choose Him as one's only protector, to entrust oneself to Him completely and, considering oneself insignificant, constantly and humbly to cry out within to the feet of Hari, guru and the Vaishnavas. One who has surrendered lives bodily in the places of Bhagavan's pastimes, says with his lips and knows with his mind, “Bhagavan, I am Yours,” and in that is his joy.

Sadhana-bhakti is when the bhava-bhakti that is yet to be attained is practised with the senses of a conditioned jiva; its essence is hearing, chanting and remembering in a way favourable to bhakti, and, free from other desires and from any admixture of knowledge and karma, it gives birth to the treasure of prema. Krishna-prema is eternally perfect and only awakens in a heart purified by hearing and the rest; therefore sadhana-bhakti is above all pure hearing and chanting. Sadhana is of two kinds — according to rules (vaidhi) and raganuga. Vaidhi is bhajana by the command of the shastras in those in whom raga has not awakened; all injunctions and prohibitions come down to two rules: always remember Vishnu and never forget Him.

The angas, the limbs of bhajana, are sixty-four. The first ten: taking shelter at the guru's feet; initiation; service to the guru; inquiry into true dharma; following the path of the sadhus; giving up one's own pleasures for Krishna's joy; living in a holy place of Krishna; accepting only what is necessary for life; fasting on ekadashi; honouring the dhatri and ashvattha trees, cows, brahmanas and Vaishnavas. The next ten are kept by abstaining: avoiding offences in service and offences to the Name; not associating with non-Vaishnavas; not taking many disciples; not reading many books piecemeal and not arguing over interpretations; keeping equanimity in loss and gain; not yielding to grief; not disrespecting other devas and shastras; not listening to blasphemy of Vishnu and the Vaishnavas; not listening to village gossip; not troubling anyone. These twenty are the entrance to the temple of bhajana, and the chief of them are shelter at the guru's feet, initiation and service to the guru.

Then come thirty-five more: hearing, chanting, remembering, worship, offering prayers, service, the attitude of a servant, friendship, self-surrender; dancing and singing before the Deity; petition; prostrating fully; rising to greet Bhagavan or His devotee and accompanying those who depart; visiting holy places and temples; circumambulation; reciting prayers; japa; sankirtana; smelling the fragrance of offered incense and garlands; honouring maha-prasada; seeing the arati and the Deity; offering the Lord what one loves; meditation; serving all that is “His” — Tulasi, the Vaishnavas, Mathura, the “Bhagavatam”; every effort for Krishna's sake; awaiting His mercy; celebrating the days of His appearance with the devotees; complete surrender; the vows of the month of Karttika and others. Four more belong to arcana: wearing the marks of a Vaishnava, the letters of Hari's name and remnants offered to the Lord, and drinking charanamrita. And the last five: association with sadhus, chanting the Name, hearing the “Bhagavatam,” living in Mathura and serving the Deity with faith and love. This is service with the body, the senses and the mind; some angas are quite separate, others merge with one another.

These last five are the best. Some perform one anga, some many, and from steadiness in them prema dawns; Ambarisha and others performed many, while by a single anga Krishna's feet were attained by Parikshit — through hearing, Shukadeva — through chanting, Prahlada — through remembering Vishnu, Lakshmi — through serving His feet, Prithu — through worship, Akrura — through prayers, Hanuman — through service, Arjuna — through friendship, Bali — through self-surrender. A devotee who has surrendered completely owes nothing to the devas, sages, ancestors and the rest: leaving the

dharma of injunctions, he serves Krishna; his mind is not drawn to what is forbidden, and an accidental sin committed in ignorance Krishna in His mercy removes entirely, purifying him as the inner guru. Knowledge and renunciation are not limbs of bhakti; they may be called two sons who follow in her train, and without bhakti they bring no good, while non-violence and other virtues come to a pure devotee of themselves.

Ragatmika-bhakti is the natural bhakti, full of raga, of the eternally perfect residents of Vraja: the gopis, Nanda and Yashoda, Shridama, Sudama and others; there is no such bhakti anywhere else, and the bhakti that follows it is raganuga. The nature of ragatmika is deep thirst for the beloved object, its mark is complete absorption. Hearing of it, a rarely fortunate person acquires a longing (lobha) to follow it, and only this longing, born of hearing about the sweetness of the feelings of the Vrajavasis, gives the right to raganuga-bhakti: neither scripture nor reasoning produces it. One who longs for ragatmika follows the deeds of the Vrajavasis in the body of a sadhaka, relying on kirtana, while in a mental body fit for eternal service in the perfected form he serves under the guidance of the resident of Vraja he loves. A raganuga-bhakta always follows in the steps of Sri Gurudeva — a Vrajavasi dear to Krishna — and inwardly serves Krishna without cease; he remembers Krishna and the associate of His whom he has chosen, speaks of them, and always lives in Vraja — if not in body, then in a pure mind.

Prema and the Rasas

Then the Lord revealed prayojana, the goal that is attained — prema-bhakti. Bhava, or rati, is the still "liquid," sprouting state of prema; when it thickens and ripens, it becomes prema. Bhava softens the heart with rays of ruchi, like the sun of prema, and its nature is shuddha-sattva; when it has softened the heart completely, become imbued with a deep sense of "mine" and thickened, that is prema. An undivided sense of "mine" towards Krishna — "Krishna alone is the object of my sense of 'mine,' and no one else" — joined with prema, the mahajanas call prema-bhakti.

The way to it is this: from piety favourable to bhakti comes faith in bhakti that knows nothing else; then association with sadhus, pure devotees; hearing and chanting; removal of anarthas (according to the measure of hearing, and of the gross ones from the very beginning); steadiness; taste; attachment; and when attachment is purified, bhava, or rati, the sprout of love for Krishna; and at last, thickening, prema, the abode of all bliss. Up to taste and attachment it is sadhana-bhakti, then bhava-bhakti, and after it prema-bhakti. Sprouted bhava is known by nine signs: equanimity where there is cause for agitation; not a moment spent apart from what is connected with Krishna; detachment; absence of pride in an exalted position; firm hope of service; intense longing for the desired; a natural unfailing taste for chanting the Name; attachment to describing Krishna's qualities; love for the places where He dwells. The words, deeds and signs of those who love Krishna are incomprehensible even to learned knowers of the shastras: from love of repeating the name of the Beloved they now languish, now, forgetting public opinion, laugh, weep, cry out, sing and dance like madmen.

Prema deepens by stages — sneha, mana, pranaya, raga, anuraga, bhava and mahabhava — just as from molasses one gradually obtains khandasara, sugar, sugar-candy and the purest candy; in the same way the relishing of rasa differs with the stages of prema. According to the kind of rati it is fivefold — shanta, dasya, sakhya, vatsalya and madhura — and in these five rasas Krishna becomes subject to His devotees. Transcendental rati is the permanent sentiment (sthayi-bhava); when vibhava, anubhava, sattvika and vyabhichari combine with it, rasa is born, and in krishna-bhakti — krishna-bhakti-rasa. The sthayi-bhava is its root, vibhava the cause, anubhava the effect, sattvika a special effect, vyabhichari the helpers. Vibhava is divided into alambana (the support) and uddipana (that which awakens); in the alambana the abode of love (ashraya) is the devotee, its object (vishaya) is Krishna, and the uddipana is Krishna's qualities.

The outward expressions of love (anubhavas) are thirteen: dancing, rolling on the ground, singing, loud crying, twisting the body, loud exclamations, yawning, heavy breathing, disregard of public opinion, drooling, loud laughter, whirling and hiccups — and they do not all come at once but at different times. The spiritual transformations (sattvika-bhavas) are eight: stupor, perspiration, horripilation, faltering of the voice, trembling, change of colour, tears and fainting. The transitory feelings (vyabhicharis) are thirty-three: nirveda, vishada, dainya, glani, shrama, mada, garva, shanka, trasa, avega, unmada, apasmara, vyadhi, moha, mrityu, alasya, jadya, vrida, avahittha, smriti, vitarka, chinta, mati, dhriti, harsha, autsukya, augrya, amarsha, asuya, chapalya, nidra, supti and bodha. The ornament-bhavas are twenty: born of the body — bhava, hava and hela; arising without effort — shobha, kanti, dipti, madhurya, pragalbhata, audarya and dhairya; and natural — lila, vilasa, vichchhitti, vibhrama, kilakinchita, mottayita, kuttamita, vibboka, lalita and vikrita.

In shanta-rasa rati grows up to prema, in dasya up to sneha, mana, pranaya and raga, in sakhya and vatsalya up to anuraga, while in Subala and those like him, though they are in sakhya-rasa, it reaches even bhava; in madhura — up to mahabhava. Rudha- and adhirudha-mahabhava exist only in madhura-rasa: rudha is seen in Dvaraka, adhirudha only in Gokula. Adhirudha is of two kinds — madana in union and mohana in separation — and in them manifold feelings appear; the extreme stage of divine madness is in separation. Union (sambhoga) is of countless kinds, separation (vipralambha) of four: purva-raga, pravasa, mana and prema-vaichittya; the first three are found in the gopis headed by Radhika, while prema-vaichittya is especially known in the queens of Dvaraka.

Bhagavan Krishna Himself, the son of the king of Vraja, is the crown of heroes, and Radha is the crown of heroines. Of Krishna's countless qualities sixty-four are chief: fifty are present as drops in all jivas and as an ocean in Krishna; five more, great ones, are present fully in Vishnu and partly in Shiva and other devas; Narayana, the Lord of Vaikuntha, has five more, sixty in all; and Krishna eternally and fully has four more special ones — sixty-four in all. Radha's twenty-five qualities attract even Krishna. Krishna-bhakti-rasa cannot be tasted by those devoid of bhakti: only Krishna's transcendental devotees are entitled to relish it.

Four Commissions

“Sanatana,” said the Lord, “I have briefly explained to you the prayojana-tattva. Earlier, in Prayaga, at the Dashashvamedha ghat, I invested your brother Rupa with power and told him of krishna-rasa.” And He gave Sanatana four commissions:

“My dear Sanatana! I ask you too constantly to spread and preach the sacred scriptures devoted to the science of devotion to God, and also to revive throughout Mathura the forgotten places of pilgrimage connected with Krishna's pastimes. I entrust you with laying the foundation of how Sri Sri Radha-Krishna should properly be served in Vraja and how all Vaishnavas should conduct themselves. Establish this science of bhakti in your works and preach this teaching from Vrindavana.” (CC, Madhya 23.97–98)

To establish in the world the siddhanta of pure bhakti; to restore the lost tirthas of Mathura-mandala and determine their locations; to manifest the Deity of Krishna in Vrindavana and show how He is to be served; to compile a Vaishnava smriti and introduce Vaishnava sadachara, thereby laying the foundations of Vaishnava society — these were the four tasks.

The Lord also spoke of renunciation. What is desirable for the jiva is yukta-vairagya — renunciation in which the world is used in connection with Krishna; while phalgu-vairagya — dry renunciation which, regarding the world as maya, rejects as transient and illusory even what is used in Krishna's service — is always to be rejected. Sanatana questioned the Lord further and heard the true meaning of the accounts

of the mushala-lila, Krishna's departure, His appearance “from a hair” of Vishnu and the abduction of the queens, as well as the most confidential conclusions of the “Bhagavata”:

“Such descriptions as the destruction of the Yadu dynasty, Krishna's departure, the abduction of the queens or the appearance of Krishna and Balarama from hairs of Vishnu are products of illusion and wholly contradict all the conclusions of the science of devotion to Krishna. Then Sri Chaitanya explained to Sanatana Gosvami how all these stories are rightly to be understood.” (CC, Madhya 23.111)

These accounts do not describe the eternal transcendental lila: they are given to bewilder people of demoniac nature who are hostile to Vishnu.

Then Sanatana, holding a straw between his teeth, said with great humility:

“‘O my Lord! I am the lowest of men. I constantly served unworthy people and so lost all my former merits. And yet You have revealed to me knowledge so confidential that even the creator Brahma cannot grasp it. You have told me the highest truths, which lead to the boundless ocean of the nectar of immortality. But my mind cannot touch even one drop of this ambrosia of eternal life. If You wish me, a cripple, to begin to dance, then bless me and place Your lotus feet on my head. Please say, “May all that I have told you be revealed to you.” By blessing me so, You will give me the strength to set out this knowledge in my books.’ Then Sri Chaitanya Mahaprabhu touched Sanatana Gosvami's head with His hand and blessed him: ‘May all this be revealed to you!’” (CC, Madhya 23.114–118)

At Sanatana's request the Lord gave sixty-one explanations of a verse of the “Bhagavata”:

“Even sages who rejoice in the self (atmarama), free from all bonds, render selfless service to Urukrama: such are the qualities of Hari.” (“Bhagavatam,” 1.7.11)

To Sarvabhauma the Lord had once given eighteen explanations of this verse, to Sanatana He gave sixty-one; along the way, telling the story of Narada and the hunter, He glorified association with sadhus. And when Sanatana offered Him praise, the Lord revealed the meaning and greatness of the “Bhagavata.”

With joined palms Sanatana said: “You have ordered me to compile a Vaishnava smriti, but I am low and understand nothing of such judgments. Only if You teach me how to do it and Yourself enter my heart can an unworthy man accomplish this service. You are Ishvara: whatever You make one do will be accomplished.” The Lord answered: “Whatever you wish to write, Krishna will reveal to you; still, I shall give you a few sutras as a direction.” And He listed the subjects of the future book (CC, Madhya 24.319–340): shelter at the guru's feet; the characteristics of guru and disciple and their mutual testing; the object of worship; mantras, the right to a mantra, perfection in a mantra and purification; initiation; morning remembrance and morning duties; cleanliness, achamana, cleaning the teeth, bathing, sandhya-vandana; service to the guru; the urdhva-pundra, the marks of the disc and other symbols, gopi-chandana, wearing garlands offered to Krishna; gathering tulasi; preparing clothes, seat and house; awakening Krishna and worshipping Him with five, sixteen, fifty, ten and sixty-four articles; service at the five times of day, arati, Krishna's meals and rest; the characteristics of the Deity and of the shalagrama; pilgrimage to Krishna's places and darshana of His Deities; the glory of the Name and the avoidance of offences to the Name; the characteristics of a Vaishnava; the removal of offences in service; the characteristics of the conch, water, fragrances, flowers and incense; japa, prayers, circumambulation and obeisances; the rules of purashcharana; honouring prasada and refusing what is unoffered; avoiding blasphemy of Vaishnavas; the characteristics of sadhus, association with them and service to them, rejection of bad company; hearing the “Bhagavata”; daily, fortnightly and monthly duties; Ekadashi, Janmashtami, Vamana-dvadashi, Rama-navami and Nrisimha-chaturdashi, observed on a pure rather than a “mixed” tithi, the sin of non-observance and the bhakti that comes from

observance; the manifestation of Deities and the building of temples of Vishnu; general and Vaishnava sadachara, what should and should not be done, the customs of smriti. And everything was to be supported by sayings of the Satvata Puranas. Thus for two months in Kashi the Lord imparted the whole bhakti-siddhanta to “His own man,” Sanatana.

At that same time the Lord delivered the Mayavadi sannyasis of Kashi headed by Prakashananda and taught them the unprecedented bhakti-siddhanta of the Brahma-sampradaya, explaining especially that the “Bhagavata” is the genuine, natural commentary on the “Brahma-sutra”; from that day the sannyasis of Kashi became devotees of Mahaprabhu.

“All the inhabitants of Varanasi began to sing Krishna's holy name. Feeling a surge of love for Him, they all laughed, wept, sang and danced. From then on the sannyasi theologians took up the study of the ‘Srimad Bhagavatam.’ Thus Sri Chaitanya Mahaprabhu delivered all the inhabitants of Varanasi.” (CC, Madhya 25.158–159)

Then the Lord took leave of the devotees one by one and decided to go alone to Nilachala through Jharikhanda, while He told Sanatana to go to Vrindavana, to Rupa and Anupama.[35] With great compassion He charged him with caring for the devotees who would come to Vrindavana:

“All My devotees who come to Vrindavana are, as a rule, very poor. Please, Sanatana, take care of them all, for sometimes they have only a torn wrap and a water-pot.” (CC, Madhya 25.176)

First Time in Vraja

Sanatana went to Vrindavana by the high royal road, while Rupa and Anupama, after spending a month in Vrindavana, set out to look for him by the road along the Ganga and came to Prayaga. Two brothers went one way, the third another, and they missed each other: in Prayaga Rupa learned that Sanatana had already gone on to Mathura.[36] This is told in detail in the article on Rupa Gosvami.

At the Lord's bidding Subuddhi Raya, who had formerly served Hussain Shah, had also come to Vrindavana. He was atoning for his past sins by chanting Krishna's names, barely feeding himself by selling dry firewood, and helped the Vaishnavas who came from Bengal. He had known Sanatana as a minister and loved him dearly, and at their meeting he showed him the courtesy and affection of their former worldly relations, wishing to serve him; but Sanatana remained indifferent to this and out of humility would not accept his service. From Subuddhi Sanatana learned that he had missed his brothers, and when he went round the twelve forests of Vraja with him and with a Sanoriya brahmana, he heard from them that Rupa and Anupama had made this circuit shortly before and gone off along the Ganga to Bengal.

A great renunciant, Sanatana searched for Krishna day and night in the forests of Vrindavana:

“Sanatana Gosvami was immeasurably detached from the transient world. He constantly wandered through the forests of Vraja, spending days and nights in various groves. He collected books on the glory of Mathura and uncovered the hidden places of the divine pastimes as he wandered through the forests of Vraja.” (CC, Madhya 25.207–208)

Shortly before, on His own circuit of Vraja, Mahaprabhu had discovered Radha-kunda and Shyama-kunda near the village of Arit and had seen Harideva at Govardhana. He also wished to see Madhavendra Puri's Giridhari Gopala, whose temple stands on the hill, but He had vowed not to set foot on Govardhana. Then a rumour spread that Muslims were coming to destroy the Deities of Vraja, and the pujaris hid Gopala in the village of Gathuli (Ganthuli) — and so the Lord received darshana. Later too Gopala would from time to time “move” to Gathuli in this way, and Sanatana also had the good fortune to see Him there. By the Lord's order neither Rupa nor Sanatana climbed Govardhana, regarding

it as non-different from Krishna, and Gopala under one pretext or another gave them darshana at the foot of the hill, as He had formerly given it to the Lord.

Meanwhile, in Kashi, Rupa and Anupama heard from the Maharashtrian brahmana, from Chandrashekhara and from Tapana Mishra about the Lord's instructions to Sanatana and about the deliverance of the Mayavadi sannyasis, and they rejoiced greatly. After spending half a month in Kashi, Rupa went through Gauda to the Lord in Nilachala and stayed there until the Dola-yatra.[37] Then the Lord invested him with power, told him to go to Vrindavana and to send Sanatana to Nilachala.

The Road to Puri

Rupa was delayed in Bengal, missed the devotees' annual journey to Puri and arrived later; he stayed with Haridasa, and when the Lord asked about him and about Sanatana, he told how the brothers had missed each other. When Rupa returned from Nilachala to Gauda, Sanatana set out alone from Vrindavana for Puri by the forest road through Jharikhanda: some days he fasted, on others he chewed a little dry madhukari; he endured many hardships, and in his heart lived deep despondency (nirveda) and humility.[38]

From the bad water of Jharikhanda and long fasting, what looked like an itching rash broke out all over Sanatana's body; when he scratched the itching places, fluid oozed from them.[39] Sanatana displayed this illness in his transcendental body for the instruction of the people: its cause was not karma but lila, by which he taught jivas sick with the disease of worldly existence and bound by karma to condemn themselves and feel nirveda. Some look in illness for an excuse and a pretext to rest from serving Hari, but Sanatana only grew humbler. On the way he reflected:

"'I come from a low caste, and besides, my body has now become unfit for progress on the path of devotion to God. When I reach Jagannatha Puri, I shall not be able to enter the temple of Lord Jagannatha. And I shall not be able to see Sri Chaitanya constantly either. I have heard that Sri Chaitanya lives near the temple of Lord Jagannatha. But I shall not be able even to come near that temple. Lord Jagannatha's servants are always going about their business there. If they touch me even by accident, I shall offend them. Therefore, if I sacrifice this body in a fitting place, it will bring me relief and then lead me to the spiritual abode. During the Ratha-yatra Sri Jagannatha will be visible to all people. And at that time I shall give up this body under the wheel of His chariot. I shall give up my body before the eyes of Mahaprabhu and Sri Jagannatha, under the wheel of the Lord's chariot. Thus I shall attain the highest destination.'" (CC, Antya 4.6–12)

With this resolve Sanatana came to Nilachala, found Haridasa Thakura's dwelling and bowed at his feet; and when he began to long for the Lord's feet, Haridasa told him that the Lord would soon come.[40]

"Your Body Is My Own Property"

Having seen Jagannatha's upala-bhoga, the Lord came with His devotees to Haridasa. Seeing Sanatana, He was surprised and delighted and went to embrace him, but Sanatana drew back:

"'Lord, I beg at Your feet — do not touch me. I am a fallen man, born in the lowest caste. Besides, my whole body is covered with festering sores.'" (CC, Antya 4.20)

But the Lord embraced "His dear great devotee" by force — so tightly that the discharge from the sores soiled His body, and Sanatana's heart broke. Then the Lord introduced him to all the devotees, among them Svarupa Damodara, and sat with them on a raised place, while Sanatana in his humility sat lower down. The Lord asked him about the devotees of Vraja and told him of Rupa's visit and that Rupa had gone to Gauda, while Anupama had "attained the Ganga" — had left his body. Sanatana humbly glorified the Lord's causeless mercy and told of his younger brother's faithfulness to Sri Rama — from

childhood to the end of his life.[41] The Lord told Sanatana to live with Haridasa Thakura and sent maha-prasada to them both through Govinda.

In his great humility Sanatana did not enter the temple of Jagannatha but bowed only to the chakra, the disc on its top. Like Haridasa, and like Rupa before him, he lived at Siddha-bakula and did not go to the Lord, while the Lord Himself came every day after the upala-bhoga to Sanatana and Haridasa and held intimate talks about Krishna with them (CC, Madhya 1.63–65).

One day the omniscient Lord, coming to Haridasa's dwelling, spoke of Sanatana's former intention:[42]

"'My dear Sanatana, if I could attain Krishna by suicide, I would at once and without hesitation give up My life millions of times over. It is impossible to attain Krishna merely by giving up one's body. He can be attained only by selfless worship and devotion. There is simply no other way. Suicide and similar acts, performed under the influence of ignorance and passion, cannot give us understanding of Sri Krishna's transcendental nature. Without unconditional devotion love for Krishna will never awaken. And without such divine love it will be impossible to attain Krishna. <…> Of these nine kinds of bhakti, chanting Krishna's holy names is the highest form of worship of God. If the holy name of God is chanted without selfishness and free of all offences, anyone will be able to attain the treasure of love for Krishna.'" (CC, Antya 4.55–58, 71)

Through Sanatana the Lord taught the world: suicide is an act of tamas; Krishna is not attained by it, but only by pure bhakti, the best of whose nine forms is harinama-sankirtana. A body given for service must not be destroyed; and what concerns the Lord is not the outward purity of the body but the inner purity of the desire to serve.

Hearing the Lord, Sanatana was greatly astonished and, for the instruction of the jivas and in accordance with the Lord's design, displayed the pastime of giving up the vain desire to leave his body. He said: "You are omniscient and merciful, You are the independent Ishvara; as You make me dance, so I dance, like a wooden puppet. I am low, fallen, insignificant by nature — what use is it to You if I remain alive?" (CC, Antya 4.74–75). The Lord answered:

"'You belong to Me entirely. You have surrendered to Me completely and thereby lost the right to dispose of your body on your own. Where does this desire come from in you to destroy another's property? Have you forgotten how to tell right from wrong? I have many purposes, and your body is the chief instrument by which I shall accomplish them. <…> The holy abode of Mathura-Vrindavana is immeasurably near and dear to My heart. In that holy place I wish to preach all these truths and much more. But by My mother's command I now live in Jagannatha Puri. Therefore I cannot settle there to teach all people the religion of the Vaishnavas. But through you I can do all this to perfection. Yet you have decided to give up your body. How can I calmly accept that?'" (CC, Antya 4.76–78, 81–83)

And the Lord accomplished through Sanatana all that He had planned. He had him write the "Brihad-bhagavatamrita" and through it established the truths about the devotee, bhakti and krishna-prema; He had him compile the "Hari-bhakti-vilasa" and established the duties and sadachara of a Vaishnava; through Sanatana's wondrous service He introduced Deity worship in Vrindavana, and through his exemplary life, full of the bliss of bhajana, mental service in Vraja; by restoring the lost tirthas — kundas and other places — and by his whole life, full of the rasa of bhakti and of renunciation, Sanatana taught the life of renunciation that pure devotees should follow.

Sanatana glorified the Lord as the puppeteer and himself as His puppet:

"A wooden puppet dances, carrying out the will of the puppeteer, without understanding at all how it manages to sing and dance. O my Lord, sometimes You make someone dance, and he dances, obeying Your sweet will. He does not understand how this happens or what the cause of his dancing is." (CC,

Antya 4.85–86)

The Lord entrusted Haridasa with the care of Sanatana's body. And when the Lord had gone, Haridasa began to glorify Sanatana's good fortune and in his natural humility said of himself:

“But Sri Chaitanya did not accept my body as an instrument for carrying out His desires. Though I was born in India, there is no meaning in this birth of mine!” (CC, Antya 4.98)

Sanatana answered him:

“‘O Haridasa Thakura, listen to me. Can anyone compare with you? You are the closest associate of Sri Chaitanya Mahaprabhu. Therefore there is no one more fortunate than you! Sri Chaitanya descended to earth to preach the glory of chanting the holy names of God. And He accomplishes this mission of His through you, O Haridasa Thakura. Every day you unceasingly chant three hundred thousand holy names of God and tell everyone of the glory and importance of chanting these all-auspicious holy names. There are those who always follow spiritual principles and injunctions but do not preach to others, and those who instruct others but do not follow it in their own lives. But you not only chant the holy names of God but also preach their glory and the importance of chanting them. You are the true teacher of the whole world and the greatest of God's saintly devotees.’” (CC, Antya 4.99–103)

The Burning Sand

The Ratha-yatra came, the devotees from Gauda arrived in Nilachala, and Sanatana was amazed at the Lord's wondrous dancing before the chariot. When the devotees from Gauda and from Orissa gathered for chaturmasya, the Lord introduced Sanatana to them all; and by his qualities — his learning and virtue — he won everyone's love:

“Sanatana Gosvami became dear to all the Vaishnavas through his deep knowledge and lofty qualities. According to their position the Vaishnavas showed him mercy, befriended him or honoured him.” (CC, Antya 4.112)

When the devotees from Gauda returned home, Sanatana stayed at the Lord's feet and with Him saw the Dola-yatra and other festivals.

In the terrible heat of the month of jyaishtha the Lord tested Sanatana. One day at noon He came to the garden by the temple of Yameshvara Shiva (Yameshvara-tota), took His meal there at the devotees' request and called Sanatana to it.[43] At midday the sand by the sea was as hot as fire; but feeling only one thing — “Mahaprabhu has called me” — Sanatana joyfully walked barefoot across the burning sand of the shore, not by the main road from the Simha-dvara. The soles of his feet were scorched and blisters rose, but he noticed nothing, absorbed in the thought of how to please the Lord. When he reached Yameshvara-tota, the Lord was resting after His meal; Sanatana received from Govinda the plate with His remnants, honoured the prasada and approached the Lord.

The Lord asked which way he had come. “Along the seashore,” Sanatana answered. “How could you walk on the hot sand?” said the Lord. “You could have come by the cool road past the Simha-dvara. The sand has given you blisters — you cannot even walk!” “It did not hurt much,” Sanatana replied, “I did not even notice the blisters. But it is not fitting for me to walk by the Simha-dvara: Jagannatha's servants go that way, and if I should touch them by accident, I would be ruined.” Hearing of such exemplary conduct, which gives honour to others, the Lord rejoiced greatly at heart:

“‘O Sanatana! Though you are the saviour of the whole world and can purify even the gods and great sages by your touch, the nature of devotees is such that they always strive to observe all the rules and injunctions of the scriptures. Observing such etiquette is the true ornament of saintly Vaishnavas. Whereas one who transgresses the directions of the scriptures only becomes a laughing-stock.

Moreover, he loses both happiness and good fortune, in this life and the next. You always follow all the spiritual injunctions, and by this you have greatly pleased Me. Who but you can set others an example of such proper saintly conduct?'" (CC, Antya 4.129–132)

Greatly pleased, the Lord embraced Sanatana tightly — "His dear one, with a transcendental body"; the discharge from Sanatana's sores touched the Lord's body, and Sanatana, seeing this, suffered greatly and with humble entreaties tried again and again to hold Him back.

It is worth pondering deeply what this conduct of the devotee and of Bhagavan teaches the people of our age. Sanatana, first in birth, learning, knowledge and renunciation, so guarded maryada, and Bhagavan, despite the apparent sufferings of His beloved devotee, valued it so highly: one who sings Hari's name must be free of vanity and give honour to others. Today, in communities striving for worldly prosperity, examples of vanity are seen in the form of mass movements; the pastimes of the devotee and Bhagavan warn against them and set before those who chant the Name a lofty and beneficial ideal — to seek no honour and to honour others (amani-manada). Guarding maryada is the ornament of one who worships Hari; he is never proud or envious, and humility and compassion for the sorrows of others are his eternal nature.

The Nectar of Intimacy and the Bitter Nim

The next day Jagadananda Pandita came to Sanatana. After talking of Krishna, Sanatana told him his grief: "I came here to give up this vile body, unfit for service, before the chariot, but the Lord held me back. And now He embraces me again and again, and I fall into an even greater offence: the discharge from my sores touches His body. This I cannot bear: pain, shame and fear of offence. I came for my good, but by misfortune it has turned out the other way. Tell me, what will now be for my good?" "You should live in Vrindavana," Jagadananda answered. "See the Ratha-yatra and go there." "Excellent advice," said Sanatana. "Vrindavana is the land the Lord has given me; there I shall go."

On another day the Lord came to Haridasa's dwelling and lovingly embraced him. Sanatana prostrated himself fully from a distance; the Lord called him again and again to embrace him, but he, fearing offence, would not come. Then the Lord Himself quickly went to him; Sanatana drew back, but the Lord seized him by force, brought him and embraced him tightly. And the helpless Sanatana spoke in humility:

"'I came here to attain the good, but everything has turned out the other way. I am unfit for the service of God. Instead of serving, every day I commit nothing but offences. By nature I am low and sinful. O my Lord, when You touch me, by that very fact I offend You. Moreover, my blood oozes from festering sores and soils You, but You pay no attention to it and by force embrace me again and again. You feel no aversion in touching my repulsive body. And this offence of mine will ruin me completely. If I stay in Jagannatha Puri, I shall attain no good. Please allow me to return to Vrindavana after the Ratha-yatra. I spoke with Jagadananda Pandita, and he too advised me to return to Vrindavana.'" (CC, Antya 4.151–156)

Then the Lord displayed a pastime of anger at Jagadananda:

"'Jagadananda is still a boy, yet he has become so proud that he considers himself entitled to advise even you and other senior Vaishnavas. In spiritual and worldly affairs you have always stood in the position of guru to him. Yet he tries to instruct you, quite failing to understand his own position. Everyone respectfully accepts your spiritual authority. And even to Me your advice is very important. How dare this boy try to instruct you?'" (CC, Antya 4.158–160)

Sanatana fell at the Lord's feet:

“‘Lord! You constantly give Jagadananda the nectar of Your love to drink. But me, praising me before everyone, You give only the bitter juice of nim and nishinda. I am unfortunate because to this day You have not drawn me close to You. Truly, You are the independent Lord of the whole creation.’” (CC, Antya 4.163–164)[44]

When our gurus strictly punish or scold a devotee who serves them unceasingly and selflessly, we think he has fallen, and we consider ourselves, who receive no such punishments, faithful servants. But a servant truly dear to the guru judges as Sanatana did: a rebuke is a sign of intimacy. And the proud, who imagine themselves the guru's favourites and “Vaishnavas,” offend the feet of the genuine disciple who has been granted the guru's merciful chastisement, and at a stroke lose the service of the feet of the guru and the Vaishnavas. If the Lord scolds a devotee, the devotee should consider it great good fortune.

The Lord was somewhat abashed and explained the nature of His love for Jagadananda and for Sanatana and the meaning of the rebuke: Jagadananda is not dearer to Him than Sanatana, but He cannot tolerate a breach of propriety; Sanatana is an acknowledged knower of the shastras, and the Lord praises him not from aloofness but for his virtues. And of Sanatana's body He said:

“You consider your body something repulsive, but to Me it is like a vessel of ambrosia. Sanatana, listen! Your body only seems material; in reality it is wholly spiritual. Yet you go on regarding it as worldly. I could not neglect your body even if it were material. In the highest spiritual reality there are no worldly notions that divide everything into ‘good’ and ‘bad.’ <…> Since I am a monk, a sannyasi, My duty is to make no distinctions and to regard everything equally. I perceive mud and fragrant sandalwood paste alike. Therefore I cannot reject you. For if I felt even a trace of aversion towards you, I would thereby break My vows.” (CC, Antya 4.172–174, 179–180)

Everyone has his own position, explains Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati: one who imagines himself higher breaks the etiquette owed to his seniors and instructs those to whom he should show respect; the Lord checked such breaches in juniors like Jagadananda. By His rebuke of Jagadananda He taught everyone respect for senior Vaishnavas such as Sanatana.

Haridasa Thakura objected:

“‘Lord! All that You have just said is only an outward formality. And so I cannot fully agree with it. You are known in all the worlds as the One who is especially merciful to fallen souls. We are fallen, and only for that reason have You generously accepted us.’” (CC, Antya 4.181–182)

With a smile the Lord revealed the true feeling of His heart:

“‘To Me you are like children in My care. And a guardian does not take seriously any childish pranks or faults. I do not consider Myself worthy to receive your respect, for I love you as My children. When a child soils itself, it may soil its mother, but she feels no aversion to it. On the contrary, every time she cares for her beloved little one, her happiness only grows. To a mother the child's urine and stool are like sandalwood paste. And in just the same way I feel no aversion when I touch Sanatana's sores.’” (CC, Antya 4.184–187)

“You are Ishvara,” said Haridasa; “mercy is Your nature, and Your deep heart is unfathomable to a tiny jiva: in Your mercy You embraced Vasudeva, covered with rotting leprosy, and his body became as beautiful as Kandarpa's.” Then the Lord said: a Vaishnava's body is never worldly — it is transcendental, full of consciousness and bliss. When at initiation a devotee surrenders to the guru's feet, Krishna accepts him as His own and makes him like Himself; this surrendered body manifests a nature of consciousness and bliss, and in it the Vaishnava serves Krishna's feet (CC, Antya 4.191–194). Krishna manifested the sores on Sanatana's body and sent him here to test Me; had I not embraced him out of squeamishness, I would have offended Krishna. Already on the first day I perceived from the

body of Sanatana, an associate of Bhagavan absorbed in Krishna's service, the fragrance of transcendental sandalwood, camphor, musk and kunkuma.[45]

And the Lord called Sanatana again: “Do not grieve: embracing you, I am very happy. Stay with Me this year, and next year I shall send you to Vrindavana.” He embraced Sanatana once more — and all the sores vanished, and his body shone like gold (CC, Antya 4.199–201).[46] In Puri the Lord also arranged Sanatana's meeting with Advaita and Nityananda, as He had Rupa's earlier, and asked Them to bless him.[47]

Back to Vrindavana

Sanatana lived in Nilachala together with Haridasa Thakura, and they talked unceasingly of the Lord's qualities and deeds. After the Dola-yatra, having lived in Puri a whole year, Sanatana set out for Vrindavana at the Lord's bidding; at their parting both the devotee and Bhagavan felt the sharp pain of separation. He went by the same forest road through Jharikhanda by which the Lord had once gone, and from the words of Balabhadra Bhattacharya, the Lord's companion on that journey, wrote down all the pastimes Mahaprabhu had displayed in the villages, by the rivers and hills along the way.[48] Meeting the Lord's devotees and following the road marked by His feet, Sanatana was overwhelmed with prema at the sight of the places of His pastimes; and so he came to Vrindavana.

More than a year had passed since the brothers parted when Rupa too came from Gauda to Vrindavana. The brothers lived in Vraja and carried out the Lord's fourfold command:

“Having met in Vrindavana, the two brothers began to live together, carrying out Sri Chaitanya's will. They collected a great many sacred scriptures and searched out all the forgotten holy places. At those places they built shrines and began the worship of Krishna there.” (CC, Antya 4.217–218)

Jagadananda in Vraja

When Jagadananda Pandita wished to go to Vrindavana, the Lord gave him instructions:

“‘In Mathura stay constantly in the company of Sanatana Gosvami and show due respect to the feet of all the senior Vaishnavas. Lovingly honour all these saintly devotees of Mathura, but do not associate closely with them. Nor should you try to imitate their conduct and worship. Visit all twelve forests of Vrindavana together with Sanatana Gosvami, never leaving his company for a moment. Do not stay long in Vrindavana, and return at once to Jagannatha Puri. Do not climb the sacred hill of Govardhana to see the Deity of Gopala. And tell Sanatana Gosvami that soon I shall come to Vrindavana again. Let him prepare a dwelling for Me.’” (CC, Antya 13.36–40)

The residents of Vraja relate to Krishna in pure vatsalya, and a person with a mood of reverence, seeing this, may come to disrespect them, whereas there must be no disrespect towards the Vrajavasis. Therefore, the Lord explained, those who have not attained the path of raga should not live long in Vraja: seeing deeds of the Vrajavasis that appear blameworthy, they lose faith. It is better, having visited Vraja, to return soon. And Govardhana is Bhagavan Himself in visible form, and one must not climb it.

Jagadananda went by way of Benares, where he saw Tapana Mishra and Chandrashekhara, and in Mathura he met Sanatana. Sanatana showed him the twelve forests, and after seeing Mahavana last, the two settled in Gokula, in Sanatana's cave.[49] Sanatana lived on madhukari, while Jagadananda cooked for himself in a nearby temple. As Bhaktivinoda Thakura explains (“Amrita-pravaha-bhashya”), Sanatana made do with a few flatbreads a day, while Jagadananda, unaccustomed to wheat, could not do without rice; in those days rice and dal were not regularly offered to the Deities in the temples of Vraja. What he cooked Jagadananda offered to Mahaprabhu and honoured this prasada together with Sanatana.

One day Jagadananda invited Sanatana to a meal. Sanatana came and sat at his door, his head wrapped in a cloth that a certain sannyasi had given him. Jagadananda, thinking it a gift from Mahaprabhu, was overwhelmed with prema and asked where the cloth came from. “It was given to me by a sannyasi named Mukunda Sarasvati,” Sanatana replied. Hearing this, Jagadananda flew into a terrible rage, seized the pot of rice from the hearth and rushed to strike Sanatana with it; Sanatana was greatly embarrassed, and the Pandita, putting the pot back on the hearth, said:[50]

“‘You are one of the chief associates of Sri Krishna Chaitanya Mahaprabhu. No one is dearer to Him than you. And despite this you have wrapped your head in a cloth given you by another sannyasi! Who could bear such a thing?’ Sanatana Gosvami answered: ‘O Jagadananda! You are a great saint who has grasped the conclusions of all the scriptures. No one is dearer to Sri Chaitanya than you. Such strong faith in Sri Chaitanya is certainly worthy of you. Had you not shown this faith now, how would I have known of it? I tied this cloth on my head only to see the strength of your faith. Now I have convinced myself how extraordinarily strong your love for Sri Chaitanya is. It is not fitting for a Vaishnava to wear a monk's saffron cloth. I shall certainly give it to someone.’” (CC, Antya 13.56–61)

It is not fitting for a nishkinchana Vaishnava, said Sanatana, to wear saffron like sannyasis who follow rules alone: he would give the cloth to some wanderer. Sanatana's deep devotion pacified Jagadananda.[51]

For about two months Jagadananda Pandita lived with Sanatana in Vrindavana, and when he was about to leave for Nilachala, Sanatana with great love sent with him for Mahaprabhu transcendental gifts of Vraja: sand from the place of the rasa-lila, a stone (shila) from Govardhana, dried ripe pilu fruits, a garland of gunja and other things. In Puri the Lord and the devotees especially enjoyed the pilu fruits: most of them did not know how they are eaten, but they ate them because the fruits came from Vrindavana. And on Dvadashaditya-tila Sanatana found an old shrine, renovated it and chose it as a dwelling for Mahaprabhu, fulfilling His request; later on that site the temple of Radha-Madana-mohana was built first of all.

Raghunatha Bhatta, Jiva, Raghunatha Dasa

When Tapana Mishra attained Kashi-dhama, his son Raghunatha Bhatta, deeply detached, left home and came to Mahaprabhu's feet. After eight months there he went at the Lord's bidding to Rupa and Sanatana in Vrindavana. The brothers embraced him lovingly, and all the Gosvamis accepted him as a spiritual brother; he gave himself into their care, lived with them and every day read the “Bhagavatam” to them in a sweet voice, and tears and trembling of prema again and again interrupted his reading. Jiva, the most learned son of Vallabha-Anupama, who by then had attained Vaikuntha, also gave up everything after his studies in Benares and, with the mercy and at the bidding of Nityananda Prabhu, came under the care of Rupa and Sanatana in Vrindavana; he wrote and spread many books on bhakti.

When Gaurasundara and His “second self,” Svarupa Damodara, had withdrawn from sight, Raghunatha Dasa, tormented by separation, came from Purushottama-dhama to Vrindavana resolved to see the feet of Rupa and Sanatana and then to throw himself from a height and give up his body. But the brothers protected Raghunatha, maddened by separation: his body was given to Mahaprabhu's service, and through it many of the Lord's desires would be fulfilled. They kept him with them as the “third brother” of their love and listened unceasingly from his lips to the Antya-lila of Mahaprabhu, the embodiment of the pastimes of separation, and were themselves enriched by listening. Once Raghunatha, having bathed in the Manasi-ganga, sat in bhajana under a tree in a thicket, and a tiger came to drink; Sanatana was nearby and saw that Raghunatha did not stir in the face of danger, and he told him to build a hut and perform his bhajana in it.[52]

A song by the poet Radhavallabha Dasa about Raghunatha tells that, having resolved to give up his body, he went to Govardhana, but Rupa and Sanatana saw him and held him back, and at their bidding he settled by Radha-kunda; Raghunatha is non-different from Rupa, “his shelter is Sanatana”; and when Rupa and Sanatana withdrew from sight, his eyes went blind — “what use are eyes, whom is there to see?” — and day and night he wept: “Ha Chaitanya Mahaprabhu, ha Svarupa, ha Rupa-Sanatana!”

The opening verses of the “Sri Vaishnava-toshani” show that when Sanatana began his commentary on the Tenth Canto of the “Bhagavatam,” Gopala Bhatta and Raghunatha Dasa were at his side:

“Where Gopala Bhatta and Raghunatha Dasa, nourished by a special love for Radha, lend their help, every goal is attained.” (“Vaishnava-toshani,” 13)

And Raghunatha Dasa in the “Vilapa-kusumanjali” glorifies Sanatana as the one who gave him sambandha-jnana:

“Me, blind and unwilling, he with great effort made to drink the rasa of bhakti joined with renunciation; that ocean of mercy, who suffers at the suffering of others — in that master, Sanatana, I take shelter.” (“Vilapa-kusumanjali”)

Thus the six Gosvamis — Rupa, Sanatana, Raghunatha Dasa, Raghunatha Bhatta, Gopala Bhatta and Jiva — came together, founded the “Sri Sri Vishva-vaishnava-raja-sabha” and preached Mahaprabhu's cherished desire. The Vishva-vaishnava-raja-sabha was first founded by Rupa and Sanatana, and it was founded anew by Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati on 5 February 1919 in Calcutta.

Life in Vraja

How Rupa and Sanatana lived in Vraja was told in Puri by eyewitnesses:

“‘They live in the forest, having no home of their own. Every night they sleep under a new tree. Sometimes they come to the houses of brahmanas and gather a little alms. Having given up all enjoyments, they eat only dry flatbread and roasted chickpeas. Their only possessions are a water-pot, a patched quilt and a worn wrap. They constantly chant Krishna's names, speak of Him and dance in jubilation. They worship Krishna all day and night and sleep only an hour and a half. <…> They write books devoted to bhakti-rasa.’” (CC, Madhya 19.127–131)

And the Lord's associates, hearing this, said: what is surprising in this for one who has received His mercy?

Earlier still, when Rupa was in Puri, the Lord, asking everyone to bless him, said to Ramananda Raya of Sanatana:

“His elder brother, Sanatana, is so wise and learned that there is no one who could compare with him. His detachment from everything worldly is as strong as yours, Ramananda. In him humility, detachment and unsurpassed learning are united.” (CC, Antya 1.200–201)

Thus the Lord Himself pointed out that Sanatana's renunciation is the same transcendental renunciation as Ramananda's: as Ramananda, while seemingly remaining a householder, is the crown of the teachers of yukta-vairagya, so Sanatana, sleeping each night under a new tree and living on dry chickpea flatbreads, is the model of a teacher of yukta-vairagya; and both nourish the rasa of Mahaprabhu's separation.

Sanatana lived now in Vrindavana, now at Govardhana, now by Pavana-sarovara, now in Mahavana, now by Radha-kunda, now in other forests of Vraja, and every day by vow he circumambulated Govardhana. When he went round Vraja, the inhabitants of every village — children and old people, women and men — charmed by his simplicity, regarded him as their nearest and dearest, as one of their

own.

Living at Chakra-tirtha near Govardhana, Sanatana constantly circumambulated the hill. Chakra-tirtha lies on the northern bank of the Manasi-ganga; on the bank stands the temple of Chakreshvara Shiva, popularly called Chakleshvara Mahadeva, and Sanatana's bhajana-kutir was under a nim tree in front of this temple, with the temple of Gaura-Nityananda a little to the north. When Sanatana first came to Chakra-tirtha, mosquitoes would not let him either chant the Name or write, and he decided to leave. But that night in a dream Chakreshvara told him not to worry: there would be no more disturbance. Since that night there have been no mosquitoes at Chakra-tirtha.

One of the biographies tells that the brothers also cared for the service of Madhavendra Puri's Gopala. When His pujaris, driven out by Krishnadasa's men (on this see the article on Madhavendra Puri), came to Vrindavana to Rupa and Sanatana, who were living then in burning separation from Gaura, the brothers, hearing that the service of Gopala, the treasure of Madhavendra's life, would pass to the royal officials of Mathura, handed over Gopala's service and temple to Vitthalanatha, the son of Vallabhacharya, and arranged for Gaudiya pujaris.[53]

Madana-mohana

One of the Lord's four commissions was the service of the Deity (see above), and Sanatana fulfilled it: the “Bhakti-ratnakara” and other books tell how he revealed in Vrindavana the service of Sri Madana-gopala. In the “Brihad-bhagavatamrita” he again and again calls Madana-gopala his chosen Deity, his ishta-deva. Having spent much time searching out the holy places of Vraja, he established the service of Madana-mohana, as Rupa established that of Govindaji: in Vrindavana Rupa built the temple of Govinda, and Sanatana the temple of Madana-mohana.

Krishnadasa Kaviraja speaks of the three Deities of Vrindavana — Madana-mohana, Govinda and Gopinatha:

“These three principal Deities have for ever captured the hearts of all the Gaudiya Vaishnavas. I worship Their beautiful feet, for They are the Lords of my life.” (CC, Adi 1.19)

They are Krishna, Govinda and Gopijana-vallabha, to whom the mantras of the Gaudiyas are addressed — the Lords of sambandha-jnana, abhidheya and prayojana. Madana-mohana, the Lord of Vrindavana, is the treasure of Sanatana's life, as Govinda is the Lord of Rupa's life (see the article on Rupa Gosvami).[54]

How Madana-gopala came to Sanatana is told by the “Bhakti-ratnakara”:

“Wondrous are the pastimes of Sanatana Gosvami: from time to time he lives in Sri Mahavana. There he sees with his own eyes how Madana-gopala plays with the boys on the sandbank of the Yamuna. Madana-gopala, subject to Sanatana's love, one day in the guise of a dream says to Sanatana: ‘Sanatana, your hut pleases Me; I shall come here from Mahavana.’ Saying this, the Lord vanished; Sanatana was beside himself with prema. The devotee knows well the Lord's designs: at dawn Madana-gopala came. Sanatana's heart became boundlessly glad; in a hut of leaves he serves the Lord.” (“Bhakti-ratnakara,” 2.455–461)[55]

The story is also told in more detail. In Mahavana, near the birthplace of Krishna, Sanatana made himself a grass hut and performed his bhajana there. One day, while begging alms, he came to a hamlet on the Yamuna where Madana-mohana was playing with the cowherd boys. Seeing Sanatana, the boy cried, “Baba!” — ran up, caught him by the hand and begged to go with him. “I eat only dry flatbread and coarse rice,” said Sanatana. “Then I will eat the same,” the boy replied; but Sanatana sent him back to his parents. That night the boy, laughing, appeared to him in a dream: “Baba, My name is

Madana-mohana; tomorrow I shall come to you.” Sanatana woke in ecstasy, opened the door of his hut — and saw on the threshold a wondrous Deity illumining all the directions. Coming to himself, with tears of love he began the worship with abhisheka. Rupa, seeing the Deity, was filled with prema and sent word by messenger to the Lord in Puri. Thus, having received power from Mahaprabhu (shakti-sanchara) and His command, Sanatana revealed Madana-gopala from Mahavana — as Rupa revealed Govinda from the Yoga-pitha at Goma-tila.

But one thing grieved Sanatana:

“Sri Madana-mohana is the son of a great king, yet He eats dry flatbread — Sanatana grieves.” (“Bhakti-ratnakara,” 2.462)

The whole day went in begging, and in the evening Sanatana offered the Deity the flatbreads (ruti) he had gathered, sometimes with shak or other vegetables, but he never cooked with oil and salt: there was no time to beg for them, for the Lord had given him the service of writing books. Madana-mohana saw that Sanatana wished to serve Him royally and was grieving, and He Himself arranged for His service to increase:

“Knowing Sanatana's thoughts, Madana-gopala at once wished His service to be enlarged.” (“Bhakti-ratnakara,” 2.463)

At that time Krishnadasa Kapur, a wealthy merchant (sheth) from Multan, “the best of kshatriyas,” was sailing along the Yamuna to Mathura on business. His boat ran aground, and the local people told him of the great sadhu Sanatana.[56] Inspired by Bhagavan, he left the boat and came to the Gosvami. Sanatana was sitting in his hut writing — wearing only a kaupina, emaciated by austerity. Kapur fell at his feet with great humility and begged for mercy — for some service to Madana-mohana. Sanatana touched him with his hand, seated him on a grass mat and said, “I am a beggar; tell everything to Madana-mohana.” Kapur bowed to the Deity and promised to give all his profit to His service. That same day a storm and a downpour raised the water of the Yamuna, the boat floated free, and Kapur understood that this was Madana-mohana's mercy.

“He fell at the Gosvami's feet, rolling on the ground, and humbled himself greatly, bathed in tears. Sanatana showed him great mercy and entrusted him to the feet of Sri Madana-mohana. <…> That very day he began to build the temple and had [the Deity] adorned with various jewels. Garments and other things of every kind he had carefully kept in a separate storeroom. He prepared all kinds of provisions for offerings: ‘The Lord will eat,’ — and he was very glad.” (“Bhakti-ratnakara,” 2.466–470)

Kapur gave the whole profit of his successful trading for a splendid temple with a bhoga-shala — a storeroom for the finest foods — and arranged daily offerings of many dishes. From then on Madana-mohana was served royally, and Sanatana was very glad; soon he accepted Krishnadasa Kapur as his disciple and gave him initiation.

“Who, seeing Madana-gopala, can keep his composure? The people of Vraja float in an ocean of happiness. I have told this healing story briefly: Madana-mohana is the life of Sanatana.” (“Bhakti-ratnakara,” 2.471–472)

The hut where Sanatana served Madana-gopala stood on the Dvadashaditya-tila (also called the Aditya-tila) — the highest hill by the Yamuna in Vrindavana, where, as told above, Sanatana prepared a dwelling for Mahaprabhu; on this spot Krishnadasa built the temple.[57] The old temple of Madana-mohana stands there to this day, about forty feet above the bed of the Yamuna; it is some sixty feet high, and on the door of the natya-mandira on the north side an inscription survives: “Samvat 1684, Shravana” (1627 AD). All Gaudiya Vaishnavas honour this temple as one of their chief places of pilgrimage.

In the manuscript “Seva-prakatya,” kept by Pandita Banamali Lala Gosvami of the Radha-ramana-ghera, it is recorded that Sanatana installed the Deity of Madana-gopala in Vrindavana in 1590 Samvat (1533 AD), on the second lunar day of the bright fortnight (shukla-dvitiya) of the month of Magha, and entrusted the service to the pujari Krishnadasa Brahmachari.

Later, to save the Deity from the oppression of the padishah, Madana-mohana was taken from Vrindavana to Jaipur; then the Maharaja of Jaipur gave Him to his brother-in-law, Gopala Singh, the Raja of Karauli, and today Madana-mohana is served in a temple built by the king of Karauli. And on 4 October (apparently in 1922) the old temple of Madana-mohana in Vrindavana was visited by Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati.

Srila Bhaktivedanta Swami calls Sanatana the ideal spiritual master, because he leads one to the feet of Madana-mohana: by his mercy even one who has forgotten his relationship with the Lord can live in Vrindavana and obtain every spiritual good.

The Deity of Sambandha

The “Chaitanya-charitamrita” opens with obeisances to the three Deities of Vrindavana, and first of all Krishnadasa Kaviraja glorifies Madana-mohana:

“O Sri Sri Radha-Madana-mohana! I am lame and of meagre intelligence, and my sinful mind is captured by base objects. I pray to You: grant me attachment to the priceless wealth of my life — Your lotus feet. And may Your Lordships, so compassionate and loving, be ever and everywhere victorious!” (CC, Adi 1.15)

Srila Bhaktivedanta Swami explains: Kaviraja first bows to Madana-mohana, Sanatana's Deity, who establishes our relationship with the Lord (sambandha); then to Govinda, Rupa's Deity — the “acting” Deity, who accepts service; and finally to Gopinatha. Following Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati, he teaches that the three Deities are worshipped at three stages of the path: Madana-mohana restores the forgotten relationship with the Lord and is therefore needed by beginners, Govinda accepts service, and Gopijana-vallabha — Gopinatha — is realised in perfection.

Jiva Gosvami, in his commentary on the “Brahma-samhita” (translated by Srila Bhaktisiddhanta), discloses the three key words of the eighteen-syllable Gopala-mantra: “Krishnaya” points to Madana-mohana, the object of sambandha-jnana, whose acharya is Sanatana; “Govindaya” to the Deity of abhidheya, whose acharya is Rupa; “Gopijana-vallabhaya” to Gopinatha, the Deity of prayojana, whose acharya is Raghunatha Dasa. Therefore Raghunatha Dasa, the acharya of prayojana, sees the highest goal in the feet of Rupa, the acharya of abhidheya, while Rupa always honours Sanatana, the acharya of sambandha, as his spiritual master.

So too Bhaktivinoda Thakura, explaining the Lord's conversation with Ramananda Raya, finds the three Deities in the kama-gayatri: Krishna-Kamadeva is Madana-mohana, who establishes the relationship; Pushpa-bana is Govinda, who accepts service; Ananga is Gopijana-vallabha, the highest goal. And in the commentary on the verse of the “Brahma-samhita” about the sound of Krishna's flute entering Brahma (“atha venu-ninadasya trayi-murti-mayi gatih…,” 5.27),[58] it is said that this sound is the gayatri, the basis of sambandha, abhidheya and prayojana, and that the word “trayi-murti” points to the three murtis — Madana-mohana, Govinda and Gopinatha; hearing it, Brahma became twice-born and offered the prayers “chintamani-prakara-sadmasu…” (5.29).

The order “Madana-mohana — Govinda — Gopinatha” is the very path of the sadhaka: relationship, service, the highest goal. Sanatana, the acharya of sambandha-jnana, stands at the beginning of this path, and his Deity helps one to conquer the senses and fix the mind in service. Therefore, in the words of one of the biographies, Sanatana holds a special place in the sampradaya: his books are a storehouse

of nectar, his humility is indescribable, and he is an intimate associate of Mahaprabhu and of Radha-Krishna and the guru of Rupa.

Wondrous Stories of Vraja

Sanatana, as already said, circumambulated Govardhana every day by vow. It is told that in his old age, when he manifested the pastime of infirmity and could no longer walk the seven kroshas round the hill each day, Krishna Himself, the lifter of Govardhana, came to him in the form of an unknown boy of Vraja. He gave Sanatana a govardhana-shila bearing the print of His foot, told him to circumambulate this stone instead of the hill, and vanished. To the last day of his manifest pastimes Sanatana circumambulated this shila.[59] Where it is kept today is told in different ways.[60]

In the mood of separation Sanatana searched for Krishna through the forests of Vraja. Once, in a secluded grove by Pavana-sarovara, absorbed in the rasa of love for Krishna, he was performing bhajana without taking food or water. Then a cowherd boy came to him with a pot of milk: “You are eating nothing — the cowherd girls told me.” “Why did they not come themselves?” “They have work at home.” The boy would not sit down: he had to milk the cows, and he would fetch the pot tomorrow — and he vanished. Sanatana understood that it was Krishna, and drank the milk, drowning in tears. From that day he lived by madhukari, taking a little food from many residents of Vrindavana. And on the bank of Pavana-sarovara Krishna, through the hands of the Vrajavasis and without Sanatana's knowledge, built him a hut.[61] Thus in separation Sanatana sought Krishna, and Krishna Himself took care of him: the milk, the hut at Pavana-sarovara, the shila from Govardhana.

Two more stories are connected with Radha-kunda and Rupa; they are told in detail in the article on Rupa Gosvami. Once Sanatana came to Radha-kunda to Rupa and Raghunatha Dasa, and he was troubled by a verse of Rupa's “Chatu-pushpanjali” that compares Radha's braid to a black serpent. Bathing in Radha-kunda, he saw cowherd boys and girls at play, and behind one girl's back he thought he saw a venomous snake; he cried out, ran up — and saw Sri Radha Herself. The children laughed for a long time, while Sanatana stood speechless and understood the truth of Rupa's comparison.[62]

Another time Radha, in the form of a young cowherd girl, brought Rupa milk, rice and sugar; Rupa cooked sweet rice, offered it to Govinda-deva and gave the prasada to Sanatana. Sanatana understood who had come, and with tears reproached himself: “Having accepted service from Her whom we long to serve, we are ruined,” — and he forbade Rupa ever again to cook sweet rice and accept such gifts, so that Radharani should not trouble Herself.[63]

There is also the story of the touchstone. A poor worshipper of Shiva — according to the “Bhakta-mala” and the “Gaudiya-vaishnava-abhidhana,” Sri Jivana Chakravarti of the village of Mankar in the Burdwan district — prayed to Shiva in Benares for many years for wealth. Shiva in a dream sent him to Vrindavana, to Sanatana: he has great wealth. The brahmana found Sanatana in meditation — emaciated, in a worn kaupina — and was filled with doubt. Having heard him, Sanatana replied that he himself lived on alms — how could he give wealth? The disappointed brahmana went away. But Sanatana, thinking it over, remembered a touchstone that had long been lying on a rubbish heap, sent for the brahmana and told him to take the stone. The brahmana was overjoyed, but, having gone a little way, he began to reflect: if Sanatana had so forgotten such a treasure, he must possess something more precious. He returned and asked about it. “There is no wealth higher than love for Krishna,” said Sanatana. “Worldly things are worthless and only multiply sorrow.” The brahmana bowed at his feet and began to beg for that wealth, and Sanatana, moved, bestowed on him krishna-prema.

Another biography, however, gives a warning: verses like the “Sparshamani” (“The Touchstone”), written in Sanatana's name by certain modern worldly poets who wished to praise his renunciation, do

not convey his renunciation. Sanatana neither held to nor preached phalgu-vairagya — the showy, false renunciation that dazzles people bent on enjoyment. From Mahaprabhu he accepted yukta-vairagya — renunciation eternally joined to the rasa of service to Krishna — and he showed the ideal of such superhuman renunciation, the summit of transcendental vipralambha-bhava, the mood of separation. To praise his renunciation in a worldly way is not to understand him.

Friends and Heirs

Of Rupa, Sanatana's younger brother and disciple, this whole article has spoken; here we speak of those who lived beside the brothers in Vraja and inherited their service. Much of this is told in more detail in the article on Rupa Gosvami.

Rupa himself glorifies his elder brother more than once in his books. In the closing verses of the "Hamsa-duta" he praises "Sakara" — turned away from worldly rasa from birth, ever serving the "Bhagavata," foremost among heroes, like the son of Vyasa; according to one of the biographies, the "Krishna-janma-tithi-vidhi" was written at Sanatana's special command, and Rupa, as in other books, respectfully calls him in the plural — "prabhupada"; and in the opening verses of the "Lalita-madhava" (1.7) he bows to Sanatana as the complete teacher of the world who once appeared as the third of the perfected ones — Sanaka and the others — and has now descended to place the secret of bhakti-rasa in the hearts of the devotees. More on this in the article on Rupa Gosvami.

Gopala Bhatta, by his parents' instruction, came straight to Vrindavana ("Bhakti-ratnakara," 1.163–165) and met Rupa and Sanatana there. They already knew of his coming and received him as a brother; he became very close to them. The brothers wrote to the Lord about him, and He replied, "Care for him as for a younger brother," — and to Gopala Bhatta He sent a kaupina and upper garments. When Gopala Bhatta's shalagrama manifested Himself as a Deity, Gopala Bhatta called Rupa, Sanatana and the other Gosvamis and on the Vaishakha-purnima of 1599 Samvat (1542 AD) held a great festival of abhisheka; the Gosvamis named the Deity "Sri Radha-ramana." Hearing of His appearance, Rupa and Sanatana hastened with the devotees to have His darshana.[64]

Old verses say of Gopala Bhatta:

"I bow to Gopala Bhatta, whose heart is flooded with love for Sanatana, who is distinguished in all things by his friendship with Sri Rupa, whose only life is Radha-ramana, who grants their desires to those who worship." ("Bhakti-ratnakara," 1.208)

And the "Vaishnava-vandana," ascribed to Jiva, says:

"Sanatana, seeking nothing for himself, composed the 'Hari-bhakti-vilasa' and other works — what devotees ought to do — under the name of Gopala Bhatta. And the wise Gopala Bhatta, living near Sanatana, devoted to the qualities of Hari, happily spent his days and nights here; constantly hearing what he told of the Lord's form and qualities, he truly counted himself blessed in every way." ("Vaishnava-vandana," 67–69)

According to the description of the manuscript, Gopala Bhatta wrote his "Sat-kriya-sara-dipika" at the wish of Rupa, Sanatana and the other Gosvamis, and Jiva at the beginning of the "Tattva-sandarbha" calls him, a brahmana from the south, a close friend of Rupa and Sanatana: he had written a book but had not put it in order.

For Jiva, Sanatana was more than an uncle and shiksha-guru. Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati writes ("Gaudiya," year 1, no. 4) that Sanatana is the parama-guru of Jiva, a follower of Rupa, while the worshipful Lord of Jiva is Sri Chaitanya-chandra. Sanatana entrusted his nephew with correcting his chief work:

“Sri Rupa composed the ‘Sri Hamsa-duta’ and other books, Sanatana wrote the ‘Bhagavatamrita’ and others. Having composed the ‘Sri Vaishnava-toshani,’ Sanatana ordered Sri Jiva to edit it.” (“Bhakti-ratnakara,” 1.791–792)

After the departure of Rupa and Sanatana, Jiva became the chief teacher of siddhanta and the head of the sampradaya.

When Rupa, displeased at Jiva's debate with Vallabha Bhatta, sent him away, Sanatana, happening to come to Nanda-ghat, found Jiva weakened by austerities, brought him to Rupa and persuaded his brother to forgive him. And when a certain digvijayi demanded from Rupa and Sanatana a written admission of defeat, Jiva's gurus yielded to him without argument; the sahajiyas say that Rupa, because Jiva then debated with that proud man, sent Jiva away for a time and relented only at Sanatana's intercession. Both stories are examined in detail in the article on Rupa Gosvami.

Jiva himself prays in the opening verses of the “Madhava-mahotsava”:

“He who, known to all by the name ‘Sanatana,’ found his temple-abode in the groves of Vrindavana — may he place his feet upon my head.” (“Madhava-mahotsava,” 3)

One of the biographies understands these words thus: to the very end Sanatana lived in Vrindavana and went nowhere else.[65] And in the “Bhakti-sandarbha” Jiva discloses, with arguments and proofs, those conclusions about bhakti which Rupa and Sanatana, “churning” the ocean of the “Bhagavatam,” set out in the “Bhakti-rasamrita-sindhu” and the “Brihad-bhagavatamrita.”

Soon after Lokanatha settled in Vrindavana, Rupa, Sanatana, Gopala Bhatta and others came to live there; they were all of one heart.[66] Sanatana remembers Lokanatha in the opening verses of the “Hari-bhakti-vilasa” and in the “Vaishnava-toshani” commentary on the Tenth Canto (“vrindavana-priyan vande sri-govinda-padashritan…” — “I honour those who love Vrindavana and have taken shelter at the feet of Sri Govinda…”). And when Mahaprabhu and His intimates headed by Rupa and Sanatana withdrew from the world, Lokanatha could not bear the separation.[67]

Srinivasa Acharya heard of Sanatana from childhood: his father, Chaitanya Dasa, told the little Srinivasa of the lives of Sanatana and Rupa and of their wondrous love for Gaura-Krishna. Mahaprabhu foretold of Srinivasa: “Through Sri Rupa and others I shall reveal the shastras of bhakti, and through Srinivasa I shall distribute the jewels of the books” (“Bhakti-ratnakara,” 2.122).[68] But when Srinivasa came to Vraja, Rupa, Sanatana, Kashishvara and Raghunatha Bhatta had already withdrawn.

Narottama, wearied on his way to Vraja, dreamt of Rupa and Sanatana: they laid their hands on his chest and fed him milk from the Lord. In Mathura he remembered the six Gosvamis headed by Rupa and Sanatana and wept; “Where is Svarupa, where Rupa, where Sanatana?..” he laments in one of his songs. And in the song “jaya sanatana rupa…” he glorifies Rupa and Sanatana as bottomless wells of prema-bhakti-rasa, embodiments of madhura-rasa (ashraya-vigraha), and prays to them to pierce his heart with the arrows of love for Radha and Krishna. In another song he laments that he did not render even a drop of service to the feet of Svarupa Damodara, Sanatana Gosvami, Raghunatha Bhatta, Raghunatha Dasa, Gopala Bhatta, Bhugarbha, Jiva and Lokanatha.

Lochana Dasa in the “Chaitanya-mangala” relates that after visiting Mathura the Lord met Rupa and Sanatana and then wandered through Vraja with Balabhadra.[69] The shiksha-guru-parampara, according to Srila Bhaktisiddhanta, is this: Mahaprabhu — Svarupa Damodara — Rupa and Sanatana (with Raghunatha Dasa, Raghunatha Bhatta and Gopala Bhatta) — Jiva — Krishnadasa Kaviraja — and onwards.

Rupa and Sanatana first met Haridasa Thakura in Ramakeli, and they knew one another's virtues. Among later acharyas, Vishvanatha Chakravarti accepted without objection Sanatana's interpretation in

the “Vaishnava-toshani” of the verse of the rasa-panchadhyayi “gopinam tat-patinam cha…” (“Bhagavatam,” 10.33.35), and in his continuous commentary on the “Bhagavatam” he followed Sanatana's “Vaishnava-toshani” on the Tenth Canto. Sanatana in the “Brihad-bhagavatamrita,” like Jiva in the “Sandarbhas,” diligently upheld Sri Chaitanya's view that the “Bhagavatam” is the true commentary on the Vedanta. According to the “Gaudiya-vaishnava-abhidhana,” a follower of Sanatana was Uddhava Dasa of Nandagrama, who lived in a hut on the bank of Pavana-sarovara.

Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati taught that fools who regard as an obstacle to bhajana the writing of books, as with Rupa, Sanatana, Jiva and Raghunatha Dasa, or having many disciples, as with Madhva, Ramanuja and Narottama, become offenders against pure preaching devotees. He himself, to establish the Vaishnava smriti, published Sanatana's “Hari-bhakti-vilasa” (together with Gopala Bhatta's “Sat-kriya-sara-dipika” and “Samskara-dipika”) and revived the Vishva-vaishnava-raja-sabha founded by Rupa and Sanatana (see above). And Srila B. R. Sridhara Maharaja in the “Prabhupada-padma-stavaka,” his hymn to Srila Bhaktisiddhanta, glorifies the service of Radha's feet, “approved by Gauranga, understood by Svarupa, honoured by Sanatana…”

Legends and False Teachings

Later on, people with ulterior desires (anyabhilashi) spread many legends about Sanatana and Rupa, and these must be received with great caution. One of them is Sanatana's former name “Amara” (see above). Others say that Sanatana whispered a mantra into the ear of his contemporary, the celebrated Oriya poet Achyuta Dasa. A pada of Achyuta Dasa himself sings that the Son of Shachi told Sanatana to go quickly and instruct Achyutananda; Sanatana gladly took him along, sat under a banyan tree, whispered into his ear the “shyama-panchakshara” mantra, initiated him into the maha-mantra, applied shyamanjana and Ganges clay to him and tied something round his neck. This Achyuta Dasa is spoken of in a book called “Nirakara Sarasvata,” and its very title betrays a book of the impersonalists (nirvishesha-vadi).

Under cover of Sanatana's name many nirvishesha teachings were spread later, and the aul, baul, darvesh and other sects also appeal to Sanatana. Some of them arose by relying on the dervish dress that Sanatana put on to conceal himself and on the words he spoke to deceive the non-Hindu jailer: “I shall become a dervish, an ascetic, and go to Mecca” (CC, Madhya 20.13; see above).

Caste and Titles

Certain modern people who fancy themselves scholars and are proud of worldly caste, not understanding Sanatana's humble words, consider him “fallen from caste” or “a man of low caste” — and so fall into the mire of offence. The meaning of those words is disclosed by the “Bhakti-ratnakara”: immersed in an ocean of humility, Sanatana considered himself lower than the mlecchas, called himself “lower than the low” because he constantly dealt with people of low caste, and, though a king among brahmanas, with great sorrow in his heart never considered himself a brahmana (see above). For the scriptures say:

“A twice-born man devoid of devotion to Hari is lower than a dog-eater (shva-pachi).”

The evidence of the brothers' brahmana lineage, however, is clear. Sanatana himself, in his commentary on the third verse of the “Brihad-bhagavatamrita,” calls Rupa his dear servant born in a brahmana family, and in the “Sanatanashtaka,” ascribed to Rupa, Sanatana is praised as “the ornament of the line of brahmana-kings of the glorious south.” Even before manifesting the pastime of taking shelter at Mahaprabhu's feet, Sanatana received in his house in Ramakeli twenty or thirty pandita-bhattacharyas and studied the “Bhagavatam” with them:

“He invited two or three dozen brahmanas learned in the Vedas, and together with them immersed himself in the study of the ‘Srimad-Bhagavatam.’” (CC, Madhya 19.17)

A certain “pandita,” proud of worldly caste, wrote that Rupa and Sanatana associated with Haridasa, who was born in a non-Hindu family. The “Chaitanya-charitamrita” shows the emptiness of this argument: Sanatana did not keep company with non-Hindu pirs, but gathered brahmana panditas at his home (see the verse above). And Advaita Acharya — the crown of acharyas, from a noble brahmana family in brahmanical Shantipur — by Mahaprabhu's command ate in one row with Haridasa Thakura and Mukunda:

“Then the Acharya wished to massage Sri Chaitanya's feet, but the Lord indignantly stopped Him, saying: ‘In many ways You have made Me dance, but now, I pray, stop this dance. Go rather and eat together with Mukunda and Haridasa.’ The Acharya then partook of prasada together with Mukunda and Haridasa, thus fulfilling the desire of His heart.” (CC, Madhya 3.105–107)

More than that, honouring Haridasa as the guru of the best of brahmanas, Advaita fed him the dish offered to the ancestors on the day of His father's shraddha:

“Advaita Acharya answered him thus: ‘Do not fear, dear Haridasa. I shall certainly act in full accord with the injunctions of the holy scriptures. You are so great that to feed you is equal to feeding ten million venerable brahmanas.’ Saying this, Advaita Acharya offered him to partake of the offering that He had made to His ancestors.” (CC, Antya 3.219–220)

The brothers' court titles — “Dabir Khas” for Rupa and “Sakara Mallik” for Sanatana — were merely ranks conferred by Hussain Shah, not a sign that their ancestors had accepted Islam: otherwise Jiva would not have called their father “the best of the twice-born, the venerable Kumara” (dvija-varah shriman kumara); and in the names of Kumara-deva and of his father, “the accomplished Mukunda,” there is nothing un-Hindu. “Dabir,” according to the “Raja-vyavahara-kosha,” is one versed in nyaya and argument (“yuktabhijno dabirah syat” — “one who knows arguments is called a dabir”), and “khas” means “one's own”: Rupa was the sultan's private counsellor. The title “mallik,” like “chaudhuri” and similar ones, was received since the time of Muslim rule by many brahmanas and Hindus, and it is quite impossible to infer from it that they or their ancestors changed their faith; “mallik” is a corruption of the local word “mahallik,” “elder in knowledge” (jnana-vriddha).[70] “Shukur,” according to the same dictionary, means “skilled in everything” (“kushalah shukurah”), and in the opinion of some “Sakara” is a corruption of this word; in any case the title “Sakara Mallik” speaks of skill and maturity of knowledge.

Sanatana was a Brihaspati in intellect — so Krishnadasa Kaviraja too says:

“Sanatana Gosvami held the post of chief minister, and in sharpness of mind he was not inferior to Brihaspati (the guru of the gods).” (CC, Madhya 20.348)

But the main thing lies elsewhere. Rupa, Sanatana and the other Gosvamis are in the bodies of associates of Bhagavan (bhagavat-parshada-tanu). Whoever considers them living beings of some high or low caste, varna or ashrama has not heard a single true conclusion of Vaishnava dharma. Rupa and Sanatana are the crown of paramahamsas beyond varnashrama, gurus even for the jagad-gurus.

The Testimony of the Poets

Sanatana's life was sung by Bengali poets as well. Radhavallabha Dasa, known as a disciple of Srinivasa Acharya, a padakarta who rendered Raghunatha Dasa's “Vilapa-kusumanjali” into Bengali verse, wrote the “Srila Sanatana Gosvamir suchaka” — Sanatana's life in condensed, “sutra” form, in the tripadi metre, in two songs. The poet's account is poetic and does not agree with the “Chaitanya-charitamrita”

in everything, but it conveys Sanatana's heart vividly.

The first song begins with Sanatana's lament in prison after Rupa had renounced the world: “Gaurahari in His mercy saved Rupa, but me, the lowly one, He did not remember. With the noose of the rope of my karma they bound my hands and neck and threw me into prison; so with the noose of Your mercy seize me firmly by the hair and lift me up to Your feet.” Sanatana compares himself to a doe caught in a trap: behind is bottomless water, on either side a forest fire, in front the hunter has set his arrow to the string. “You easily saved Jagai and Madhai, Vasudeva and Ajamila — give Sanatana too some glimmer of mercy, the boat of Your feet; save me from this ocean of sorrow, I have no one but You.” And at that very moment someone secretly passed him a letter from Rupa; overjoyed, constantly remembering Gauranga, Sanatana set out.

In the second song Sanatana, Rupa's elder brother and the padishah's vizier (ujir), receiving Rupa's letter, escapes from captivity and meets Gauranga in Kashi. He approaches stooping — in a torn kantha, with long nails and grown hair — with two bunches of grass in his hands and one in his teeth, and falls at Chaitanya's feet. Seeing him in the guise of a dervish, the Lord rushes to him in tears with open arms and embraces him. “Why touch a fallen man?” Sanatana grieves. “I am untouchable, despicable, wretched, of bad conduct, without understanding, of low birth and low deeds, unworthy of Your touch.” “Sanatana, why do you humble yourself so?” the Lord replies. “Your humility breaks My heart. Krishna's mercy does not distinguish good from bad; I touch you to purify Myself.” The Lord glances again and again at the costly blanket (bhota-kambala), and the embarrassed Sanatana gives it to a man of Gauda, takes a torn kantha in exchange and returns to the Lord.

“You will meet Rupa in Vrindavana,” says the Lord, and at His command Sanatana goes; in His mercy Gauranga taught him the sweetness of the names of Radha and Krishna. On the way he wears a torn kantha and a worn bahirvasa, his head is shaven, on his lips is the tale of Krishna's qualities; now he weeps, now laughs, now floats in the bliss of prema, now begs alms, now fasts. In Vrindavana he meets Rupa, and Rupa, his eyes full of tears of love, embraces him and speaks in a broken voice.[71] In Vraja Sanatana lives by madhukari, from house to house, and later gives up even this: he lies now in one grove, now in another, and lives on fruits and roots. He calls aloud, “Radha-Krishna! O Lord, O Lord!” — and the brothers pass the time speaking of Gauranga's qualities.

At times, absorbed within, Sanatana spends fifty-six dandas in meditation and sleeps only four dandas under a tree; he sings Krishna's name, and in sleep he sees Radha and Krishna — not a moment of idleness. Having given up every desire for enjoyment, he lives under the trees, fasts for two to four days, sometimes boils forest greens without salt and puts a mouthful or two into his mouth; a thin cloth on his body, his body grey with dust, his sides pricked with thorns. “When shall I become his servant?” Radhavallabha concludes.

A song of Manohara Dasa about Sanatana is also sung. All the worlds praise his qualities; leaving boundless happiness and wealth, he made the feet of Sri Chaitanya the essence of his life. He lived in Vrindavana and uncovered all the lost tirthas, spread the service of Sri Govinda, expounded the meaning of the “Bhagavatam,” and in incomparable books disclosed the bhajana of the Divine Couple, Their pastimes, qualities and names. His body trembled ceaselessly with love for Gaura; finding no rest, he roamed through Vrindavana and along the bank of the Yamuna, and, all trembling, in tears, crying “Rai-Kanu!”, fell exhausted — his whole body was adorned with bhavas. By his mercy one attains Vrindavana, and on him, the Gosai, Manohara meditates.

Kavi Karnapura, the son of Shivananda Sena, also wrote of Sanatana in the “Chaitanya-chandrodaya-nataka”:

"…he who was the jewelled ornament of the assembly of the lord of Gauda — Rupa's elder brother — leaving flourishing wealth, took to wife the young Lakshmi of renunciation. Within, his heart is full of the rasa of bhakti, while outwardly he bears the look of an avadhuta; like a great lake covered with duckweed, he gives joy to those who know his worth." ("Chaitanya-chandrodaya-nataka," 9.34)[72]

The "Bhakti-ratnakara" recalls this too: "Kavi Karnapura, dear to the Lord, wrote a book and told of the grace shown to Sanatana" (1.657).

Writings

Of the books Sanatana wrote at Gaurasundara's command, four are known: the "Brihad-bhagavatamrita" with the commentary "Dig-darshini"; the "Hari-bhakti-vilasa," also with the commentary "Dig-darshini"; the "Lila-stava," or "Dashama-charita"; and the "Vaishnava-toshani" ("Dashama-tippani," "Brihad-vaishnava-toshani"), a commentary (tippani) on the Tenth Canto of the "Bhagavatam."[73]

Krishnadasa Kaviraja names them twice:

"'Hari-bhakti-vilasa,' 'Brihad-bhagavatamrita,' 'Dashama-tippani' and 'Dashama-charita.' All these important spiritual works were written by Sanatana Gosvami." (CC, Madhya 1.35–36)

"Srila Sanatana Gosvami compiled the 'Brihad-Bhagavatamrita.' From this book we know all the highest truths about the path of bhakti, about Krishna and about His devotees. He also wrote a commentary on the Tenth Canto of the 'Srimad-Bhagavatam,' calling it the 'Dashama-tippani.' Thanks to this work we can understand the nature of Krishna's transcendental pastimes and of pure love for Him. He also compiled the book 'Hari-bhakti-vilasa,' in which he described in detail the code of conduct and all the duties of Vaishnavas. And how many other Vaishnava books he wrote! No one can even list them all. In them he explained the essence of the worship of Madana-mohana and Govindaji." (CC, Antya 4.219–222)

The "Bhakti-ratnakara" lists them likewise, saying that Jiva's disciple Krishnadasa Adhikari told of the Gosvamis' books in detail:

"Sanatana Gosvami has four books: the 'Bhagavatamrita' in two parts with a commentary, the 'Hari-bhakti-vilasa' with the commentary 'Dik-pradarshini,' the commentary on the Tenth Canto called the 'Vaishnava-toshani,' and the 'Lila-stava,' which is called the 'Dashama-charita': these are the four books of Sanatana Gosvami." ("Bhakti-ratnakara," 1.806–808)

Sanskrit verses are quoted there as well: "The list of compilations of conclusions among the works of the elder of them, named Sri Sanatana, is this: first, the 'Bhagavatamrita' in two parts, the 'Hari-bhakti-vilasa' with its commentary 'Dik-pradarshini,' the 'Lila-stava,' and the commentary called the 'Vaishnava-toshani'" (1.809–810). Through these books, through the service of the Deity and the restoration of the tirthas the Lord accomplished through Sanatana what was said above: He established the truths about the devotee, bhakti and Krishna-prema, the duties and good conduct (sadachara) of a Vaishnava, the service of the Deity and the inner service in Vraja (manasi vraja-bhajana), and taught pure devotees the renounced life full of the rasa of bhakti.

"Brihad-bhagavatamrita"

Sanatana himself called the book the "Bhagavatamrita." Rupa, taking its essence, wrote the "Sankshepa-bhagavatamrita" and out of humility named it the "Laghu-bhagavatamrita," the "lesser"; that is why Sanatana's book came to be called "Brihad-," the "greater." At the beginning of his book (Purva-khanda, 5) Rupa says that he briefly sets out what his Prabhu-pada Sanatana set out at length in the "Bhagavatamrita."

The “Brihad-bhagavatamrita” discloses the ontology and metaphysics of the Lord's teaching, while the “Hari-bhakti-vilasa” deals with conduct and ritual. It has two parts of seven chapters each. The first is the “Sri Bhagavat-kripa-bhara-nirdhara-khanda,” “the determination of who possesses Bhagavan's highest mercy”; its chapters are Bhauma, Divya, Prapanchatita, Bhakta, Priya, Priyatama and Purna. The second is the “Goloka-mahatmya-nirupana-khanda,” “the description of the glory of Goloka”; its chapters are Vairagya, Jnana, Bhajana, Vaikuntha, Prema, Abhishta-labha and Jagad-ananda.

The first part is a conversation between Parikshit and his mother Uttara after he has heard the “Bhagavatam” from Shukadeva. Parikshit tells how Narada searched for the one who possesses Bhagavan's highest mercy: from a brahmana of Prayaga and a king of the south to Indra, to Brahma in Brahmaloka, to Shambhu, dear to Vishnu (here the glory of Vaikuntha is sung), to Prahlada, Hanuman, the Pandavas, the Yadavas and at last to Uddhava, who longs for a place in Vrindavana and reveals the love of the gopis as the last word of bhakti. The book opens with praise of Krishna, the gopis, Sri Krishna-Chaitanya, Mathura, Vrindavana, the Yamuna, Govardhana, Krishna-bhakti and the Name; it tells of Krishna's journey to the earthly Vrindavana and His return to Dvaraka, of the glory of Nanda and Yashoda and of the prema of the gopis, and explains why devotees are not satisfied with the bhakti they have attained and why Radhika's name is not mentioned in the “Bhagavatam.”

The second part tells how the abode is attained through sadhana. A brahmana boy from Kamarupa, instructed by Kamakhya-devi, goes to Gangasagara and to Kashi; seeing the ways of Kashi, he wishes to take sannyasa, but at the word of Kamakhya and Shiva gives it up and goes on to Mathura. In Vrindavana he meets Gopa-kumara, who tells him of his own experience. Having received a mantra from a Vrajavasi, Gopa-kumara passed through the earth (the bank of the Ganga, Sri-kshetra, Vrindavana), Svarga, where he saw Vamana-deva, Maharloka, Janaloka, Tapaloka (where Pippalayana, the son of Rishabhadeva, instructed him about the darshana of Bhagavan through sahaja-samadhi) and Satyaloka, Shivaloka, Vaikuntha, Ayodhya and Dvaraka. Along the way are disclosed the difference between mukti and bhakti and the superiority of bhakti, the marks of karma, jnana, vairagya, samadhi and bhakti, ninefold bhakti and the pre-eminence of sankirtana, the avataras, the transcendental nature of Bhagavan's murti and His shaktis; Krishna is Bhagavan Himself, the source of all portions; the meaning of the names Goloka and Vrindavana is explained and Krishna's merciful pastimes in Vraja are described. The jiva rises gradually, and at the end of sadhana is Goloka; so Gopa-kumara in Vraja sees Madana-gopala, hears Krishna's flute, sees Goloka and its Lord, and realises his eternal service in sakhya-rasa.

The nine opening verses of the book glorify the youthful Lord, the ocean of sweetness, who descended to give love for His feet: through His form as Chaitanya the eternal prema of the gopis became accessible to experience. The words “chaitanya-rupat” are understood in two ways — “from His form as Sri Krishna-Chaitanya” or “from Sri Rupa Gosvami, who is close to Chaitanya” — and thus even the poor and lowly could taste the highest prema of the gopis. Then are glorified Radhika and the gopis, dearest to Bhagavan; the Son of Shachi — Hari in the dress of a sannyasi, golden, named Krishna-Chaitanya, who realised the sweetness of His devotees' love for Him and out of longing (lobha) descended to earth — to Gauda, to Navadvipa — in the form of a devotee; Mathura, Vrindavana, the Yamuna, Govardhana; Krishna-prema-bhakti, at whose feet even mukti seeks shelter; and the Name of Murari. The closing verse is an obeisance to the son of the king of the cowherds, the best of gurus, who Himself gives bhakti, makes a person His servant and rejoices in him as in a great benefactor.

In his commentary “Dig-darshini” on his own book Sanatana bows to prema-bhakti — the mother of all goals, bestowing bliss beyond the realisation of Brahman and freeing one from the taste for worldly things, whose shelter is the feet of Sri Radha-ramana and which reveals itself through following the love of the residents of Vraja; he bows to Chaitanya-chandra, who tastes the nectar of His own Name,

“taking shelter of whose rupa” people attain bhakti (here too “rupa” means both the Lord's form and His dear associate Rupa); and he says that he himself is writing this commentary, the “Dig-darshini,” which shows only a part of the desired meanings. In the conclusion he writes that this work was prompted by all the devotees, and prays that Bhagavan may be pleased with it — “Shrimach-Chaitanya-rupa” (Krishna-Chaitanya Himself, Sri Krishna, or Rupa Gosvami). In 1898 Bhaktivinoda Thakura published a Bengali translation of the “Brihad-bhagavatamrita” in two volumes.

“Hari-bhakti-vilasa” and “Dig-darshini”

By its opening verses and colophons the “Hari-bhakti-vilasa” is a book of Gopala Bhatta. Already the second verse of the first vilasa says that Gopala Bhatta, a disciple of Prabodhananda, dear to Bhagavan, gathers the “vilasas (pastimes) of bhakti” to please Raghunatha Dasa and Rupa-Sanatana. There are four opening verses in all: the author takes shelter of Bhagavan Chaitanya-deva; having consulted the sadhus, he gathers from all the shastras the necessary duties for the pleasure of the Vaishnavas; the book “Bhakti-vilasa” was born of the pastimes of prema-bhakti for the feet of the Lord of Mathura — may His devotees follow it; and may the Vaishnavas devoted to exclusive bhakti live long in Mathura-mandala, and may Kashishvara, Krishnadasa and Lokanatha shine in Krishna's forest. In the closing verses the author prays: when will my lowly head turn grey with the dust from the feet of those who always keep to good conduct for the sake of bhakti to Damodara? may I become a bee at the feet of those whose minds are full of the nectar ocean of love for Mukunda's feet and who seek nothing for themselves.

The “Bhakti-ratnakara,” however, says plainly:

“In the Bhatta's mind arose the wish to compose a Vaishnava smriti; Sanatana Gosvami knew of it at that very moment. And in Gopala's name Sri Sanatana Gosvami composed the ‘Sri Hari-bhakti-vilasa.’” (“Bhakti-ratnakara,” 1.197–198)

Krishnadasa Kaviraja too calls the “Hari-bhakti-vilasa” a work of Sanatana (CC, Madhya 1.35; Antya 4.221; see above) and describes the “sutras” of this book which Mahaprabhu gave Sanatana in Kashi (see above, “Four Commissions”); and Jiva, in the conclusion of his “Vaishnava-toshani,” listing Sanatana's works, names the “Hari-bhakti-vilasa” and its commentary.

How is this to be reconciled? Gopala Bhatta had seen in the south the good conduct (sadachara) of the Vaishnavas of Ramanuja, while there was as yet no Gaudiya compendium of smriti. From Sanatana himself he heard of Mahaprabhu's direct command to compile a Vaishnava smriti and of the Lord's instructions, and a desire arose in him to compile such a compendium for the good of future Gaudiya Vaishnavas. At Mahaprabhu's wish the compendium and its commentary were composed by Sanatana himself; but since the compendium was regarded as collected by Gopala Bhatta, and since he himself out of humility wished to hide his name, he declared Gopala Bhatta's name in the opening verse; perhaps Gopala Bhatta himself wrote that verse, making a beginning of the book. In the opinion of some, Gopala Bhatta gave Sanatana special help in the work, and therefore Sanatana out of humility named in the book not himself but him.[74]

Many consider this conclusion correct: by Mahaprabhu's command Sanatana first compiled the “Hari-bhakti-vilasa,” and its present text was edited (sampadita) by Gopala Bhatta. So too teaches Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati: the colophons at the end of each vilasa show that the book was written down by Gopala Bhatta. Its content closely follows the Lord's instructions, and it is known as the Vaishnava smriti. Some even recognise two books — the large “Bhagavad-bhakti-vilasa” of Gopala Bhatta and a concise compendium of Vaishnava smriti, Sanatana's “Hari-bhakti-vilasa”; for in the colophon of every vilasa of the present edition stand the words: “Thus in the ‘Bhagavad-bhakti-vilasa’ written by Sri Gopala Bhatta…”

Sanatana's humility can be seen here too. In the “Hari-bhakti-vilasa” he put Gopala Bhatta's name; at the beginning of the third vilasa he bows to Sri Chaitanya Mahaprabhu, whose power is boundless and wondrous — “by His mercy even a lowly man becomes an establisher of good conduct.” And in the commentary “Dig-darshini” on the “Hari-bhakti-vilasa” he is wholly silent about his own name: only in the opening verses does he take shelter of Chaitanya-deva, who gives power to Brahma and others (the power to reveal the Vedas and other shastras), who descended in mercy to give His bhakti, by whose mercy every meaning of the shastras becomes accessible, and he says that he writes “according to his understanding” the commentary “Dig-darshini,” explaining part of the meaning of the “Bhagavad-bhakti-vilasa.” This brief commentary is reputed to be Sanatana's, but the commentator's name does not appear in it.[75]

The “Hari-bhakti-vilasa” consists of twenty vilasas, each with its own name: Gaurava, Daikshika, Shauchiya, Sri Vaishnava-alankara, Adhishthanika, Snapanika, Paushpika, Pratar-archa-samapana, Mahaprasada, Sat-sangama, Nitya-kritya, Ekadashi-nirnaya, Vishnu-vrata-utsava, Shanmasika, Divya-avirbhava, Sri Damodara-priya, Paurashcharanika, Sri Murti-pradurbhava, Pratishthita and Prasadika. They speak of the guru and the disciple and of mantras; of diksha; of conduct, purity and remembrance; of the samskaras, tilaka on twelve places of the body, mudras, the mala and guru-puja; of the seat, breathing, meditation and the shalagrama; of invoking and bathing the Deity; of flowers; of incense, lamps, offerings, dance, music, garlands, prayers and offences in service; of mahaprasada and the devotees; of the worship of the Deity, the glory of the Name, offences against the Name and self-surrender; of ekadashi, fasts and Maha-dvadashi; of monthly duties; of festivals — the waterless ekadashi, chaturmasya, Janmashtami, Rama-navami, Vijaya-dashami and others; of the month of Karttika, lamps, Govardhana-puja and Ratha-yatra; of preparation for worship, the maha-mantra and japa; of the forms of Vishnu; of the installation of the Deity and the building of temples.[76]

The conclusion of the book says: what needs to be known in more detail, learn from the relevant shastra or from the lips of the guru; many customs prescribed by the shastra are not written down, since there is now no one to observe them. The book sets out chiefly the duties of virtuous wealthy householders, for without steadiness on the path of archana they cannot attain the good; but for the nishkinchana mahatmas who have renounced everything the pomp of archana is not needed: such solitary devotees sing of and remember Krishna and desire nothing else, and the merits and sins arising from injunctions and prohibitions do not touch them.

The “Hari-bhakti-vilasa” is older than Rupa's “Bhakti-rasamrita-sindhu”: in the “Bhakti-rasamrita-sindhu” (Purva-vibhaga, second lahari, verses 42 and 94) proof-verses are quoted with reference to the “Hari-bhakti-vilasa.” Some half a century after it Raghunandana Bhattacharya wrote his smriti compendium, the “Ashtavimshati-tattva.” Gadadhara's smriti “Kala-sara” quotes the “Hari-bhakti-vilasa,” and Raghunandana's “Ekadashi-tattva” and other works quote a book called “Hari-bhakti.” The “Hari-bhakti-vilasa” itself rests on a vast number of authorities — Puranas, Samhitas, smritis, Pancharatras and Tantras, and also Krishnadevacharya, Venkatacharya, Shankaracharya and others.

“Lila-stava”

Narahari Chakravarti also calls the “Lila-stava” the “Dashama-charita,” and Sanatana's “Dashama-charita” is mentioned in the “Chaitanya-charitamrita” too (Madhya 1.35). This book, known also as the “Krishna-lila-stava,” describes Krishna's pastimes up to His departure for Mathura; one of its verses — Sanatana's address to the “Bhagavata” — was quoted above.

Many considered the “Lila-stava” lost. Some see it in the “Gitavali” — the forty-one songs of the “Stava-mala” on the pastimes of the Tenth Canto, beginning with the Nandotsava, in each of which

Sanatana's name appears in one way or another;[77] but Baladeva Vidyabhushana at the end of his commentary on the “Gitavali” calls its songs “taught by Rupa” (see the article on Rupa Gosvami). In the Berhampur edition of Rupa's “Stava-mala” the name “Sanatana” stands in the closing lines (bhanita) of the songs “Saurabha-sevita-pushpa-vinirmita,” “Apaghana-ghatita” and “Damodara-rati-vardhana-veshe.” Radhamohana Thakura included them in the “Padamrita-samudra” and in his commentary interprets the name in two ways: “Krishna, who is worshipped by Girisha, Sanaka and others together with Sanatana Gosvami,” or “Sarasvati praises Sanatana Gosvami” — that is, the songs speak of the pastimes described by the Gosvami named Sanatana, honoured by Sanaka (or by Sanaka and others).

“Vaishnava-toshani”

Sanatana completed his commentary on the Tenth Canto — the “Vaishnava-toshani,” or “Dashama-tippani” — in 1476 Shaka and gave it to Jiva to correct. At his command Jiva abridged it into his own “Vaishnava-toshani,” or “Laghu-toshani,” finished in 1504 Shaka (1582 AD); hence the name of Sanatana's commentary, the “Brihad-vaishnava-toshani.” Both dates are given by a verse of the “Laghu-toshani” quoted in the “Bhakti-ratnakara”:

“This auspicious commentary was completed in [Shaka] 1476, and abridged in 1504.” (“Bhakti-ratnakara,” 1.803)

And in the conclusion of his book Jiva says that he, the insignificant Jiva, abridged the “Vaishnava-toshani” at Sanatana's command.

The “Toshani” discloses the hidden meaning of the pastimes of the “Bhagavatam” and the essence of siddhanta: it was written to set out clearly what Shridhara Svami had not expressly stated in his commentary. Its fifteen opening verses are a prayerful roll of Sanatana's whole lineage. He surrenders to Madana-gopala, the Lord of Vrindavana, and to Govinda, whose heart aches for the unfortunate; he honours Sri Krishna-Chaitanya, who descended in Gauda to distribute prema-bhakti; Madhavendra Puri with his disciples, through whom the immortal tree of Krishna-bhakti sprouted in the world; Shridhara Svami, the sole guardian of bhakti; his own teachers (see above); Advaita, Shrivasa Pandita, Nityananda the avadhuta, Gadadhara Pandita, Svarupa Damodara and the other associates of Chaitanya, by the touch of the dust of whose feet even the lowly become exalted; and those who love Vrindavana and have taken shelter at Govinda's feet — Kashishvara, Lokanatha and Krishnadasa. Then he writes that he has set out a little, according to Vaishnava siddhanta, for the pleasure of the Vaishnavas;[78] that his shelter is the Vaishnavas whose encouragement pushed him into this bold work, and that where the two friends Gopala Bhatta and Raghunatha Dasa help, every goal is attained (see above); that this work is for the pleasure of “Shrimach-Chaitanya-rupa,” and that only Vaishnavas who know the fragrance of Sri Chaitanya's feet can taste the “Vaishnava-toshani.” The commentary ends with the words: the tippani on the Tenth Canto is completed for the pleasure of Bhagavan in the form of Sri Chaitanya — that is, of Krishna in the form of Krishna-Chaitanya (or of Rupa Gosvami).

Disputed Attributions

Other works are known under Sanatana's name, but their authorship is doubtful. Rayamukuta, in his commentary “Padachandrika” on the “Amara-kosha,” mentions a “Yogashataka-vyakhyana” of Sanatana; but the “Padachandrika” was written in 1431, and Sanatana appeared in 1488 — so this is another, earlier Sanatana. Eggeling in the India Office catalogue (vol. VII, pp. 1422–1423, nos. 1584 and 1570) records a commentary by Sanatana Gosvami, the “Tatparya-dipika,” on Kalidasa's “Meghaduta”; perhaps Sanatana wrote it before meeting Gaurasundara. Aufrecht in the “Catalogus Catalogorum” names two books under Sanatana's name — the “Bhakti-bindu” and the “Ujjvala-rasa-kana”; but no earlier acharya ascribes such works to Sanatana, and Aufrecht probably

confused them with Vishvanatha Chakravarti's “Bhakti-rasamrita-sindhu-bindu” and “Ujjvala-nilamani-kirana.”

And in the “Triennial Catalogue” of the Government Oriental Manuscripts Library in Madras (ed. Mahamahopadhyaya Kuppuswami Shastri; vol. IV, part I, Sanskrit A, R. No. 3053) a small book, the “Gopala-puja,” is described as a work of Sanatana. It begins with the removal of obstructing beings “by the command of Shiva” and the viniyoga of the seat (its deity is Sri Kurma, its bija Ananta, its shakti the Earth), and ends with the instruction that, when offering naivedya, one should show the grasa-mudra, like a blossoming lotus, utter the mula-mantra with the words “shri-krishnaya naivedyam svaha,” give Krishna water for achamana, repeat the mula-mantra a hundred and eight times, offer three handfuls of flowers and circumambulate. The colophon reads: “Thus ends the ‘Gopala-puja’ composed by Sri Sanatana Gosvami.”

Passing and Places of Remembrance

Sanatana's years and the day of his passing — the full moon of the month of Vamana — were spoken of at the beginning of this article. Behind the temple of Madana-mohana, on lower ground, in a small building of red stone, Sanatana's samadhi is shown; beside it is a well of sweet water, the “Sanatana-kupa.” Every year on the day of Sanatana's passing a great festival is held here. When Ramachandra Kaviraja came to Vrindavana, by the direction of Srinivasa and Jiva he had darshana of Govinda, Gopinatha and Madana-mohana and visited Sanatana's samadhi.[79]

Sanatana is remembered in Kashi as well. The place on the bank of the Ganga where he received Mahaprabhu's instructions is called “Sri Sanatana-shiksha-lila-kshetra”; there stands the Sri Sanatana Gaudiya Math, where Vamshidasa Babaji lived for a time. Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati spoke in Kashi about Mahaprabhu's instructions to Sanatana, and in the Sanatana Gaudiya Math of Benares the Deities of Radha-Govinda were installed on the 24th (apparently of November 1932).

Rati-manjari

In Krishna's eternal pastimes Sanatana is Rati-manjari, the closest friend of Rupa-manjari. The “Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika” says:

“Rati-manjari, the dearest friend of Rupa-manjari, is also called by the wise by another name, Lavanga-manjari. She is now Sanatana, whose body is non-different from Gaura, worthy of worship by all; for the sake of the work Sanatana, the jewel among sages, also entered into him.” (“Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika,” 181–182)

The second “Sanatana” in this verse is the sage Sanatana- (Sanat-) kumara, one of the four Kumaras; and Rupa in the “Laghu-bhagavatamrita” calls his brother an avatara of the Kumaras.[80] Sanatana, “whose body is non-different from Gaura,” is regarded as an extension, as it were, of Sri Chaitanya's own body. He is called the bhakti-siddhantacharya and the acharya of sambandha-jnana: through him Mahaprabhu disclosed to the world the essence of the siddhanta of bhakti, and his Madana-mohana to this day restores in souls their forgotten relationship with Krishna.

1. One of the biographies, citing the “Gaudiya-vaishnava-abhidhana,” puts it more cautiously: “about 1410 Shaka (1488).” Another gives only the year of his appearance, 1488, and says nothing of Sanatana's departure. No one gives any other dates.

2. All the testimonies that name the day of departure agree: ashadha-purnima of 1480 Shaka. The month of Vamana in our calendar corresponds roughly to ashadha, so there is no discrepancy.

3. One of the biographies also gives regnal years (Sarvajna from 1381, Aniruddha from 1416), calls the land where Rupeshvara settled Paurastya, and counts eight daughters of Padmanabha (eighteen according to the “Bhakti-ratnakara,” 1.558) and five sons: Purushottama, Jagannatha, Narayana, Murari and Mukunda-deva.

4. According to another account, it was not Kumara-deva but his father Mukunda who moved to Fatehabad near Jessore, in the pargana of Bakla-Chandradvipa.

5. Another biography names only the three and does not mention any other sons.

6. One biography speaks of all three brothers and does not name the village; another names the village — Sakurma — but at this point speaks only of Rupa and Vallabha.

7. One of the biographies regards the name “Amara” as a tradition of people with ulterior desires (anyabhilashi) and does not accept it.

8. According to another biography, Sanatana studied all the shastras under several teachers (Sarvabhauma, Vidyavachaspati and others) and was only especially devoted to the “Bhagavatam.”

9. The words “ramabhadram vani-vilasam” are understood in different ways: here, following the “Bhakti-ratnakara,” as the names of two instructors; one of the biographies, retelling the same passage, takes “vani-vilasa” as an epithet of Ramabhadra — “the eloquent instructor Ramabhadra” — while elsewhere treating them as two persons.

10. According to another biography, Sanatana received the post of private secretary at court; there the title “mallik” is explained as “lord,” a title Muslims gave to respected wealthy families close to the government.

11. One of the biographies gives the same passage as 1.612–614 and without the words about the father's atonement; another, citing 1.609–614, speaks of the father, as the “Bhakti-ratnakara” itself does. Both references are correct: 1.612–614 is the end of the same passage. A third puts it differently: by Vedic custom it was the person who associated with a Muslim who had to purify himself, and Sanatana, paying no heed to custom, simply regarded himself as fallen from the brahmana caste.

12. One of the biographies calls this village Bhatravari and adds that brahmanas and panditas came from Navadvipa to serve the brothers.

13. The biographies describe the Lord's journey to Ramakeli in different ways. According to one, He set out from Nilachala on the day of Vijaya-dashami and went by way of Panihati, Kumarahatta and Kulia; according to another, He spent five days with Vachaspati at Vidyanagara and then came through Kulia and Maldah to Ramakeli; according to a third, after living five years in Puri He went to see the Ganga and His mother (Shachi cooked for Him for many days), visited Advaita at Shantipura, and at Ramakeli such crowds followed Him that pits were left in the road from the dust people gathered (CC, Madhya 1.163–167). The year of the meeting, 1513, is given by only one biography.

14. According to one biography, the brothers came at midnight; according to another, at night; according to a third, in the evening, when the Lord was resting under a tree on the bank of the Ganga.

15. According to the “Chaitanya-charitamrita,” the Lord gave the brothers the names Rupa and Sanatana at Ramakeli (CC, Madhya 1.208). The account of the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” is discussed more fully in the article on Rupa Gosvami. One biography attributes the words about the “third samskara” to Vrindavana Dasa himself and says that the Lord changed the names of both brothers; in the CB these words stand not in the verse but in an explanatory subheading to it (in Srila Bhaktisiddhanta's edition), and only Sakara Mallik's name is changed there.

16. One of the biographies, following the CC (Madhya 1.221–224), attributes this advice to both brothers, though further on it itself calls it “Sanatana's proposal”; likewise in CC, Madhya 16.265, the Lord recalls Sanatana's words. Another, in its chapters on Nrisimhananda and Damodara Pandita, notes that this advice was remembered at Kanai-natashala and that on Sanatana's advice the Lord gave up the journey.

17. According to one biography, “He set out again for the south.”

18. According to another account, Rupa took the rest of the wealth to Bakla-Chandradvipa and divided it there, and himself left the ten thousand coins for his brother with a grocer in Gauda.

19. According to two other biographies, the Shah first sent a physician to Sanatana, who reported that Sanatana was well and reading the “Bhagavata” with panditas; according to one of them, the Shah gently urged him to return to his duties. Here the account follows the third, in which the badshah arrives unexpectedly and in anger.

20. The biographies give the order of events differently: according to one, Sanatana was imprisoned before the campaign and refused to go to Orissa while already in chains; according to the other two, the Shah demanded that he go with him to war and for his refusal (according to one, suspecting him) threw him into prison.

21. Another biography gives Rupa's letter in prose, as above.

22. According to another biography, Sanatana offered the bribe — five thousand rupees — only after his persuasions, and told the jailer to say that the prisoner had gone to relieve himself, then to bathe in the Ganga, had jumped into the water and vanished (with no mention of fetters), while he, the jailer, would become a Sufi and go on the hajj to Mecca. And in the one by which Sanatana's speech is given here — “I shall go to Mecca, taking the dervish” (Bengali “darabesha laiya,” that is, apparently, assuming the dervish's guise; cf. CC, Madhya 20.13: “I will become a dervish”).

23. According to another biography, Sanatana had the grocer bring the seven thousand from the money Rupa had left; according to a third, he bribed the jailer with money sent by Rupa. Only one biography says that the jailer ferried him across at night.

24. So according to two biographies; according to a third, the way lay through the Hazaribagh hills.

25. According to another biography, the landholder had a palmist, who discovered that it was Ishana who carried eight coins.

26. The third biography tells it more briefly: on the way Sanatana and Ishana stopped at an inn; realising that the host meant to kill them for Ishana's gold, Sanatana had him give the man his last coin and ask for help in getting through the jungle, and the host, moved, a chief of the local robbers, led them through the jungle and the Hazaribagh hills.

27. According to another biography, Shrikanta lived in Hajipur; the third does not name Hajipur.

28. According to the other biographies — a costly blanket of Bhutanese wool, or simply a fine woollen blanket.

29. According to another biography, Chandrashekhara was a physician.

30. One of the biographies names the hell here as Maharaurava, another as Raurava.

31. So according to two biographies: the old cloth was given by Tapana Mishra (in one of them “Mishra” is named in a passage that had been speaking of Chandrashekhara). According to the third, Chandrashekhara wanted to give a new cloth, but Sanatana took his own old one: formerly he had clothed thousands of beggars, and now he did not want new cloth for himself; he tore it in two, into a bahirvasa and an uttariya. One of the biographies adds that Sanatana accepted the dress of a babaji.

32. One of the biographies gives this verse as “2.6.220”; the correct reference is Antya 6.220. The other references of that biography to the “Chaitanya-charitamrita” have been checked and are correct. Another biography gives the instructions on the “Hari-bhakti-vilasa” as “Madhya 29.326–345” (correctly Madhya 24.319–340), and the description of the Gosvamis' life in Vraja as Madhya 19.128–132 (19.127–132 in the translation from which the quotations here are taken).

33. According to the other biographies, the blanket was taken by a Bengali beggar washing his kantha at the ghat, or by a brahmana at a ghat of the Ganga.

34. So (“three gold coins”) also in one of the biographies; according to another, “worth three coins.”

35. According to another biography, the Lord went to Puri “by a little-frequented road.”

36. One of the biographies says that Rupa and Anupama went along the Ganga “to meet the Lord in Prayaga”; this is a confusion — elsewhere in the same biography they go along the Ganga to Bengal.

37. In its account of Rupa the same biography gives a stay of ten days.

38. According to one of the biographies, Sanatana came to Puri through Jharikhanda while Rupa was living for almost a year in Bengal, and returned to Vraja by the same road. Another calls this forest country “the jungles of Uttar Pradesh”; Jharikhanda, however, is the forest region between Bengal and Orissa on one side and Bihar on the other.

39. The cause of the illness — bad water and hunger — is also named by the “Chaitanya-charitamrita” (Antya 4.5); one biography speaks only of bad water, another simply of a “skin disease.”

40. According to another biography, Sanatana went straight to Siddha-bakula, and Haridasa, embracing him lovingly, himself invited him to live with him: in this way Sanatana could see the Lord when He came to Haridasa as was His custom. According to the third, Sanatana met Haridasa only after the Lord had talked him out of suicide.

41. According to the third biography, Sanatana heard the news of Anupama's departure from Haridasa. According to another, it was the Lord who told of Anupama's devotion to Rama and of his departure to Rama's abode; elsewhere in the same biography it is Sanatana who tells it: Anupama, despite his brothers' persuasions, could not give up the worship of Rama, and the Lord compared him with Murari Gupta: “In the same way I tested Murari; glory to the devotee who does not leave the feet of his Deity, and to the Lord who does not leave His devotee.”

42. According to one of the biographies, the Lord spoke allusively; according to another, directly, having come to Siddha-bakula.

43. According to another biography, in the heat of the month of jyaishtha the Lord was living at Yameshvara-tota together with Gadadhara Pandita.

44. According to another biography — the bitter juice of nim and tobacco leaves.

45. According to another biography — “chatuhsama”: sandalwood, camphor, aguru and musk; this word also stands in the “Chaitanya-charitamrita” (Antya 4.197).

46. According to the third biography, Jagadananda supposedly “permitted” Sanatana to go to Vrindavana, but the Lord did not approve, glorified Sanatana's virtues and told him to stay in Puri for a year.

47. One of the biographies speaks of this meeting as of both brothers at once, though they were in Puri at different times. For Sanatana it is confirmed by the “Chaitanya-charitamrita”: among those to whom the Lord introduced him, Advaita

Acharya and Nityananda Prabhu are named (Antya 4.108).

48. The “Chaitanya-charitamrita” (Antya 4.210) says that Sanatana learned from Balabhadra the names of the villages, rivers and hills on the Lord's route; one of the biographies stresses that he wrote them down.

49. According to another biography, the delighted Sanatana persuaded Jagadananda to live with him in Gokula, where he himself was then living.

50. According to one of the biographies, Sanatana came wearing the saffron cloth “wishing to show the world Jagadananda's devotion to the Lord,” and Jagadananda at once realised that the cloth was not from the Lord; another calls the cloth a turban of red material and does not give the sannyasi's name.

51. One of the biographies adds that Sanatana then remarked that red cloth is not fitting for Gaudiya Vaishnava sannyasis, since it is worn by the Mayavadis of Shankara's school, and that ever since, out of respect for his words, Gaudiya Vaishnava sannyasis have adopted the saffron colour for the dress of renunciation. The “Chaitanya-charitamrita” says otherwise: Sanatana said that it is precisely saffron sannyasi cloth that is not fitting for a Vaishnava (Antya 13.61), and the Lord did not approve of it on him; there is no contrast between “red” and “saffron” cloth in the CC.

52. This story is in the “Bhakti-ratnakara” (5.554–562): Sanatana, coming from Vrindavana to Radha-kunda, to Gopala Bhatta's dwelling, went to bathe at the Manasa-pavana ghat and saw a tiger drinking water there; the tiger went off into the forest past Raghunatha, who sat in meditation. Sanatana lovingly embraced Raghunatha and told him to live henceforth not under a tree but in a hut — and for the good of others Raghunatha settled in a hut. The Manasi-ganga and Raghunatha's bath are details of the biography.

53. According to the “Bhakti-ratnakara” (5.814–817), when the two brahmanas, Madhavendra's disciples, had passed away, the service of Gopala was given to Vitthaleshvara (Vitthalanatha) on the advice of “Dasa Gosvami and others”; Rupa and Sanatana are not named there. According to the tradition of Vallabha's followers, the Bengalis came to Rupa and Sanatana in Mathura, and they only said: “You know, and He knows.”

54. One of the biographies calls Gopinatha the Deity of Raghunatha Dasa — evidently in the sense that Raghunatha Dasa is the acharya of prayojana, whose Deity is Gopinatha (see below). The service of Gopinatha in Vrindavana, however, is usually connected with Madhu Pandita.

55. Another biography, citing another passage of the “Bhakti-ratnakara” (5.1777–1786 — the story Srinivasa hears on his circuit of Mahavana), tells it otherwise: living in Gokula-Mahavana, Sanatana saw Madana-gopala playing with the cowherd boys on the Raman-reti, the sandy bank of the Yamuna, while the people of Mahavana came to life on seeing Sanatana himself. One day, watching the play, he thought, “This is no ordinary child,” and followed; the boy entered a temple, and Sanatana, going in after Him, saw only the Deity of Madana-mohana, bowed down and silently returned home. Thus Madana-mohana showed that He was conquered by Sanatana's love. There is also a tradition that Sanatana received the Deity from the house of a Mathura brahmana, Damodara Chaube.

56. The running aground, the storm and the vow to give away the profit are details of one of the biographies: in the “Bhakti-ratnakara” (2.464–470) Kapur, “the best of kshatriyas,” simply leaves the boat, falls at the Gosvami's feet, receives his mercy and that same day begins to build the temple. According to another biography, Kapur was not a merchant but, “as they say,” a wealthy commander in the sultan's army; he built the temple and the kitchen.

57. According to another account, a temple was built on this hill first. One and the same biography names the hill now “Aditya-tila,” now “Dvadashaditya-tila.”

58. One of the biographies attributes this commentary to Bhaktivinoda Thakura and calls it the “Anubhashya”; but “Anubhashya” is the name of Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati's commentary, so the names are probably confused here.

59. In the “Bhakti-ratnakara” itself (5.730–741) Sanatana daily goes round Govardhana, a circuit of “twelve kroshas,” and in his old age, seeing his great labour, Gopinatha appears in the form of a cowherd boy: He wipes away his sweat and brings him from Govardhana a shila with the print of His foot. According to one biography, citing this passage, the circuit was fourteen miles; Gopinatha in the form of a cowherd boy first fanned the tired Sanatana, then climbed the hill and brought the stone, and Sanatana wept at losing sight of Him. According to another, also citing the “Bhakti-ratnakara,” the circuit was “four miles”; the cowherd boy urged him, “Baba, you are old, give up this rule,” — Sanatana answered, “I will not give up the principles of bhajana,” — and then Krishna gave him the shila with the print of His foot, and Sanatana understood that it was Giriraja Himself who had given it.

60. One biography says that the shila is now in the temple of Radha-Damodara at Radha-kunda. According to a widespread view it is worshipped in the temple of Radha-Damodara in Vrindavana, in whose courtyard is Rupa's samadhi (see the article on Rupa Gosvami); there are other traditions as well. The question is disputed, and we do not decide it.

61. So too in the “Bhakti-ratnakara” (5.1298–1310). According to another biography, Krishna told Sanatana to build the hut himself and serve Him; according to a third, the Vrajavasis built it in the course of time.

62. In the “Bhakti-ratnakara” (5.754–765), to which the biography refers, the story is shorter: at the Govinda-ghata of Radha-kunda the girls, when Sanatana rushed to warn them, vanished with a slight smile, and he, coming to himself, said to

Rupa: “What you have written is the truth.” That he saw Radha Herself and that the children laughed for a long time are details of the biography.

63. One of the biographies speaks only of Sanatana reproaching himself, another only of the prohibition; the second adds ghee to the gifts and in one place names the scene as Teri-kadamba, where Rupa performed bhajana (near Nandagrama), in another as Pavana-sarovara.

64. The year of the festival is given here in the Samvat era. One of the biographies (in its account of Rupa) gives it as “1599 AD” — a confusion of eras: 1599 Samvat is 1542 AD, within the lifetime of Rupa and Sanatana.

65. This interpretation cannot be taken literally: from Vrindavana Sanatana went to Mahaprabhu in Puri and then returned (see above). What is meant is evidently his life in Vraja after his return.

66. According to another biography, Lokanatha, a few days after coming to Vrindavana, met Rupa, Sanatana, Gopala Bhatta, Bhugarbha and others there; it does not say who came first.

67. One of the biographies says in one place that Lokanatha, coming to Vrindavana, learned that Rupa and Sanatana had already withdrawn, and in another that Narottama found Rupa, Sanatana and Lokanatha in Vraja. The second does not agree with the first: Narottama came to Vraja only after the brothers' departure (see below).

68. So in the “Bhakti-ratnakara” (2.122: “sri-rupadi dvare”). The biographies retell this prophecy as “through Rupa, Sanatana and others.”

69. According to the “Chaitanya-charitamrita,” the Lord met the brothers in Ramakeli, Prayaga and Kashi, not in Vraja; Sanatana came to Vraja only after Mahaprabhu had left it (see above).

70. Another biography explains “mallik” as “lord” (see above).

71. According to the “Chaitanya-charitamrita,” when Sanatana first came to Vraja he did not find Rupa there: the brothers missed each other and met in Vrindavana only after Sanatana's return from Puri (see above). The poet brings these events together.

72. In one of the biographies this verse is cited as 9.45; in the translation used here it is 9.34 (the numbering of the editions differs).

73. One of the biographies names under the second heading only the commentary “Dig-darshini” on the “Hari-bhakti-vilasa,” though elsewhere it ascribes the book itself to Sanatana as well; another names as Sanatana's “most important works” the “Hari-bhakti-vilasa,” the “Brihad-bhagavatamrita,” the “Dashama-tippani” (“Brihad-vaishnava-toshani”) and the “Dashama-charita.”

74. One of the biographies says simply that Sanatana compiled the “Hari-bhakti-vilasa” and published it under Gopala Bhatta's name. Another says that he compiled it together with Gopala Bhatta, who edited the book, and out of great love for him published it under his name; elsewhere the same biography writes that the book is based on notes collected by Gopala Bhatta.

75. Another biography regards the “Dig-darshini” on the “Hari-bhakti-vilasa” as beyond any doubt a work of Sanatana.

76. The contents of the vilasas are given after one of the biographies (in Srila Bhaktivedanta Swami's summary); the tenth vilasa is omitted there.

77. Elsewhere in the same biography (in the account of Rupa) the songs of the “Gitavali” are counted as forty-two; here, as with Baladeva Vidyabhushana (“forty and one more”), as forty-one.

78. So one of the biographies renders this passage in Bengali. The Sanskrit verse, as printed there, says otherwise: “vaishnavaparitoshah” — he has set out a little where [in Shridhara Svami] the Vaishnavas might have remained unsatisfied.

79. So in two biographies: in one, by the direction of Srinivasa and Jiva; in the other, by Jiva's command; there it is also said that Ramachandra took the dust of the feet of Lokanatha, Gopala Bhatta and Bhugarbha, who were then living. In the second biography this is the only mention of Sanatana's samadhi.

80. One of the biographies quotes only the first half of the verse of the “Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika” and does not speak of the Kumara entering him.